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- 5 अक्टूबर | दोपहर 3:00 बजे
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14 सितंबर | सुबह 8 बजे

Prayagraj Batch

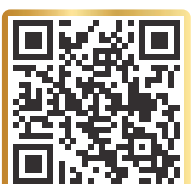


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21 September | 5:30 PM

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High Court disqualifies
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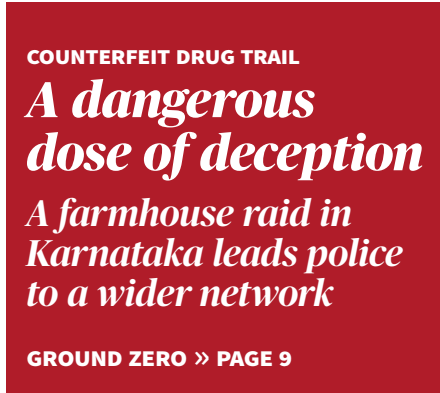
STATES » PAGE 6

**MARATHI FILM**
Gondhal
is India's
official entry
to Oscars

NEWS » PAGE 12

**FCRA BILL**
JPC members flag
asset takeover clause

NEWS » PAGE 11

**COUNTERFEIT DRUG TRAIL**
A dangerous
dose of deception
A farmhouse raid in
Karnataka leads police
to a wider network

GROUND ZERO » PAGE 9

**ASIAN GAMES**
India crushes Japan,
enters the semifinals

SPORT » PAGE 17

IN BRIEF

**DUSU polls record**
40.46% turnout,
highest in 3 years

NEW DELHI
The Delhi University Students' Union (DUSU) elections recorded a turnout of 40.46% as of 10.30 p.m. on Friday, the highest in the past three years, with around 1.51 lakh students casting their votes, a university official said. » **Page 2**

2 more women
die in Rajasthan
after C-sections

JAIPUR
Two women who underwent caesarean sections at a government hospital in Bundi died at separate private hospitals in Kota earlier this week. Bundi Collector Harphool Singh Yadav has sought a report on the incident. » **Page 4**

Data suggest Indian oil buys fall after U.S. curbs

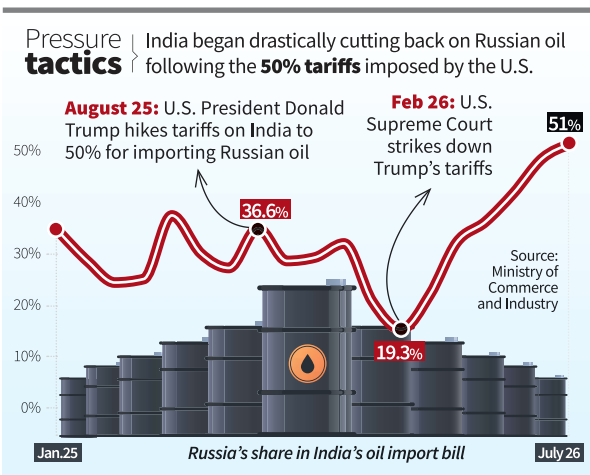
The government says energy sourcing is based on 'national interest', but India slashed imports from Venezuela, Iran, and Russia following U.S. pressure, and resumed sourcing after curbs eased

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

Over the past decade, India has complied with U.S. pressure to reduce oil imports from countries it has sought to isolate, such as Venezuela, Iran, and Russia, even though they were important sources. Once the U.S. pressure eased, official data show that India immediately turned back to these sources of oil.

The External Affairs Ministry on Thursday issued a strong statement asserting India's strategic independence in sourcing energy against the backdrop of a U.S. Bill that proposes tariffs of up to 100% on India for importing Russian oil.

The Ministry spokesperson said on Friday that



"energy sourcing is based on national interest" and that India continues "to buy energy from diversified sources". "As stated, we have already conveyed, at senior levels of the U.S. administration, the implications that the legislation could have on India's ener-

gy security, for the international energy markets, and the overall bilateral partnership," the spokesperson said.

Earlier, the Ministry said that in its communications with the U.S., the Indian side "made clear its determination to take all mea-

sures to protect its trade and economic interests".

Data show that protecting "trade and economic" interests has, in the past, coincided closely with the U.S. sanctions and tariff programme. Russia's share in India's oil imports was around 30%-40% between July 2024 and July 2025 but fell to 19.3% by February 2026 when the U.S. hiked tariffs to 50%. After the U.S. Supreme Court struck down the tariffs in February, India's oil imports from Russia increased, touching 51% this July. The share of Venezuelan crude fell from 6.7% in 2017-18 to zero by 2021-22, and that of Iranian oil plummeted from one-tenth to nil by 2020-21.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

Mamata-backed Congress nominee held in Nandigram

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Hours after her candidate withdrew from the Nandigram bypoll race, former West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee said on Friday that her party would support the Congress nominee, Milan Pradhan, in the bypoll, even as the police arrested him in connection with an old case.

The development follows the Election Commission allotting new names and symbols to the two factions of the Trinamool Congress led by Ms. Banerjee and Ritabrata Banerjee, who is the Leader of the Opposition in the West Bengal Assembly.

While the Mamata faction will be called the Mamata All India Trinamool Congress with "football player" as its symbol, the Ritabrata group was allotted the name Democratic Trinamool Congress and



Mamata Banerjee

the symbol "envelope". In an interim order issued on Thursday night, the poll body barred both factions from using the original party name, the All India Trinamool Congress and its 'Jora Ghas Phul' (two flowers with grass) symbol for the coming bypolls.

Ms. Banerjee called the decision to freeze the party name and symbol a "black day for Indian democracy" and said she would "fight it out" and emerge stronger. Congress leaders, including Rahul Gandhi, have come in support of her ov-

er the poll body's order.

Reacting to the order, Mr. Ritabrata said: "It is a fight between an individual cult and a collective. We are a collective. The individual cult is resting on an individual and chose such a name, while we have upheld the collective and the values of democracy, nationalism and secularism."

Ms. Banerjee decided to back the Congress candidate after Sanchita Pradhan (Dey) withdrew her nomination following a meeting with BJP leader and Chief Minister Suven- du Adhikari. Ms. Banerjee is also supporting the Congress in the Nagaon Lok Sabha bypoll in Assam.

The bypoll in Nandigram is being held because Mr. Adhikari relinquished the seat after getting elected from Bhabanipur and Nandigram in the polls.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

21 killed in bomb blast at mosque near Pakistan police offices

Associated Press
PESHAWAR

A vehicle bomb exploded on Friday at a mosque near police offices in northwestern Pakistan as gunmen tried to storm the compound in an attack that killed at least 21 people and wounded 80 others, police and rescue officials said. Among those killed and wounded were police officers attending prayers at the mosque.

The bombing occurred in Kohat, a district in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa. An attacker apparently rammed an explosives-laden vehicle into the mosque, said Zulfiqar Hameed, the provincial police chief.

At least seven gunmen also attempted to enter the police compound and exchanged fire with officers. Six of the gunmen were

killed, according to police, who said one suicide bomber attacked the nearby office of an intelligence agency.

The police compound housed counter-terrorism police, who had carried out operations against militants across the province in recent years.

Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif condemned the attack and expressed sorrow over the casualties. He directed authorities to accelerate rescue operations.

Photos showed the outer wall of the police offices had collapsed and the mosque was badly damaged. Smoke rose over the site after the blast, which witnesses and residents said was heard far away, followed by gunfire.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10



People gather at a mosque damaged in a suicide attack in Kohat district of Pakistan on Friday. REUTERS

'Shift to CBT for NEET-UG under active consideration'

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Centre told the Supreme Court on Friday that a switch to computer-based testing for NEET-UG 2027 remains under "active consideration", with the Nandan Nilekani-led task force, set up to recommend technological reforms for the National Testing Agency, expected to submit its report by September-end. The court directed the task force to file an affidavit and questioned when reforms would be implemented.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 12

Bail for U.S. national as NIA misses chargesheet deadline

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

A Delhi court on Friday granted default bail to U.S. national Matthew Aaron Van Dyke, who was arrested in March in connection with an alleged cross-border ethnic conspiracy involving ethnic armed groups in Myanmar. The court noted that the National Investigation Agency (NIA) did not file a chargesheet covering the alleged terror offences within the mandatory 180-day period.

Special Judge Prashant Sharma of the Rouse Avenue Courts allowed Mr. Dyke's bail application after noting that the chargesheet filed by the NIA on September 8, the last day of the statutory deadline, invoked only "piecemeal" charges of Sections 21 and



The NIA invoked just 'piecemeal' charges against Matthew Aaron Van Dyke instead of UAPA, under which he was initially booked, said the court. FILE PHOTO

23 of the Immigration and Foreigners Act, which can be settled at the level of the Foreigners Regional Registration Office, rather than the more serious Section 18 of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) under which Mr. Dyke was originally booked. Section 21 addresses

punishment for entering India without valid entry documents while Section 23 covers general contraventions, including overstaying a visa and violating visa conditions.

The court said the investigating agency cannot use an incomplete chargesheet to sidestep the default bail provision under Section 187(3) of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita.

Conditions imposed
Granting him release, the court also directed Mr. Dyke to furnish a personal bond and surety bond of ₹1 lakh each, subject to conditions including that he remain within Delhi and not leave without the court's permission.

It also asked him to refrain from influencing witnesses or tampering with

evidence, keep the Investigating Officer informed of his address, maintain an active phone number and remain available for further questioning whenever required.

Relief for 6 Ukrainians

The order also noted that the same reasoning extends to the six co-accused in the case, all Ukrainian nationals, who remain in judicial custody, and directed that copies of the order be sent to them so they may pursue their own default bail applications.

Mr. Dyke was arrested by the NIA on March 13 at the Kolkata airport. The six Ukrainian nationals were arrested at airports in Delhi and Lucknow.

According to the probe agency, the seven accused entered India on tourist vi-

sas and travelled to the north-eastern region without obtaining the mandatory permits. The NIA also alleged that they subsequently crossed illegally from Mizoram into Myanmar, where they were involved in training ethnic armed organisations.

The Central agency had initially invoked provisions of the UAPA, including those relating to conspiracy, as part of its investigation into the alleged cross-border network.

During earlier hearings, the agency told the court that the accused had made significant disclosures while in custody about the alleged conspiracy. It also claimed that the seven accused were involved in assembling equipment and had targeted a passenger aircraft in Myanmar.

India, Nepal discuss post-flood recovery, reset in bilateral ties

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

Nepal's reconstruction plans post-floods and the "reset" of India-Nepal ties with the newly elected government were at the top of the agenda as External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar met Nepal's Finance Minister Swarnim Wagle here on Friday, as both sides prepare for a visit by Nepal Prime Minister Balen Shah to New Delhi later this year.

Mr. Jaishankar said he offered his deep condolences to Mr. Wagle over the recent flash floods. "Discussed ways to strengthen our overall cooperation, especially in economic, energy and connectivity domains," he added in a social media post where he tagged the government's "Neighbourhood First" slogan.

Mr. Wagle's visit to New Delhi follows a visit by Nepal Foreign Minister Shishir Khanal in June, as part of a call by ruling Rashtriya Swatantra Party (RSP) chairman Rabi Lamichhane for a "reset" in ties between New Delhi and Kathmandu, troubled over the past few years on both boundary disputes and economic issues.

Multilateral support

Mr. Wagle met Mr. Jaishankar a day after meeting Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Thursday, during which India committed to continuing support for Nepal's recovery efforts after the floods. According to officials, the entire reconstruction required after the floods on August 26, which have left more than 1,400 dead and more than 6,000 missing,



S. Jaishankar greets Nepal Finance Minister Swarnim Wagle in New Delhi. ANI

will top \$5 billion.

Nepal will be making an appeal for multilateral support at the UN General Assembly next week in New York, as Mr. Shah is expected to make his first international speech. Mr. Wagle is in Delhi on his first visit abroad since he took office and will travel soon to Doha for a meeting of the Board of the China-led Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB) and to the IMF and World Bank meetings in Bangkok.

In a readout, the Finance Ministry said Mr. Wagle had thanked India for its assistance after the floods on the Trishuli river that overflowed in areas on both sides of the Nepal-China border and destroyed a major Chinese border crossing at Rasuwa. They also discussed the strengthening of bilateral economic ties and "initiatives to enhance connectivity for deepening of trade, investments and people-to-people exchanges". Nepal wants to explore connectivity in road and rail, but officials have said they are keen to resolve the long-pending issue of overflight for flights to Nepali airports.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

DTC strike drives metro ridership to record high

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Delhi Metro recorded its highest-ever daily passenger boardings on September 17, with 82.44 lakh boardings across the network amid an ongoing strike by Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) bus drivers, the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) stated in a release on Friday. The 82,44,903 boardings surpassed the previous record of 81,87,674 recorded on August 8 last year, according to the release. To handle the increased demand, the DMRC operated 32 additional trips on Thursday.

‘Greater reliance’

The higher ridership came as commuters faced disruptions in bus services due to the DTC strike, prompting greater reliance on the metro for daily travel, the release stated, adding that the DMRC would continue to augment its services and infrastructure to cater to the city’s growing ridership.

The citywide strike, which entered its fourth day on Friday, has been called by DTC employees demanding improved service conditions, including a minimum daily wage of ₹2,000, an annual bonus, payment for working on government holidays and medical insurance, among other demands.

Despite assurances from the government, drivers continued their protests, causing inconvenience to commuters.

DUSU polls record 40.46% turnout, highest in 3 years

Last year, turnout stood at 39.5%; polling conducted smoothly, no violence reported, says Proctor; CEO issues notice on victory processions and celebratory marches; counting and results today

Ashna Butani
NEW DELHI

The Delhi University Students’ Union (DUSU) elections recorded a voter turnout of 40.46% across 52 polling stations as of 10.30 p.m. on Friday, the highest in the past three years, with around 1.51 lakh students casting their votes, a university official said. The figure was subject to change as the final turnout was still being calculated, the official added.

Last year, the turnout stood at 39.5%, significantly higher than the previous year’s 30%.

‘Smooth conduct’

DU Proctor Manoj Kumar Singh said polling was conducted smoothly and there was no violence. “We are hoping that counting will begin as planned,” he said. Asked about violations, he acknowledged that printed campaign material had been used despite several warnings.

The polling took place in two phases, from 8.30 a.m. to 1 p.m. and from 3 p.m. to 7.30 p.m. In the first phase, the voter turnout stood at 36%. Counting will take place on Saturday, and the results will be announced as soon as counting is completed, the official said.

Ban on processions

The Delhi High Court on Friday banned victory pro-



Students queuing up to cast their votes at Miranda House on Friday; (below) students at Delhi University. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA



cessions after the declaration of election results, directing Delhi Police to ensure that no such procession is held on roads, inside colleges or hostels. The court warned that any violation would invite criminal and administrative action against the erring students and amount to contempt of court.

Prof. Raj Kishore Sharma, the DUSU Chief Election Officer (CEO), issued a

circular based on the High Court order. The notice read, “All persons must desist from organising or participating in any procession, rally, parade, or similar public demonstration that may disrupt public order or traffic or violate the court order.”

The biggest issue

Outside Hindu College in North Campus, two first-year students said “dirty

politics” should be reduced. Raghvendra Kaushal said, “Lack of hostels is the biggest issue for us. We think that since ABVP is in power and they have government backing, they should be doing more.”

Aashika, who goes by her first name and is studying in the university’s Faculty of Law, said, “What we need is canteens and metro concession passes. But nothing changes.”

The hostel issue featured prominently in manifestos this year and was a talking point among students even as they went to cast their votes on Friday.

Meanwhile, the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad and the National Students’ Union of India traded charges, accusing each other of attempting to influence electoral process.

Jantar Mantar protest fuelled interest but money, muscle persist in DU politics: students

Ashna Butani
NEW DELHI

As students went to cast their votes on Friday, some said the large-scale protests at Jantar Mantar encouraged many to “raise their voices” and take an interest in student politics. However, pointing to thousands of pamphlets strewn on the roads and showing videos of male students harassing women, they said the DUSU elections remained largely a “money-muscle” game.

The elections are usually dominated by the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad and the National Students’ Union of India. This year, the Left joint panel of the All India Students’ Association and the Students’ Federation of India, along with the AAP’s Association of Students for Alternative Politics, hope to carry the Jantar Mantar momentum into the elections.

The Left has campaigned on the claim that “progressive forces” have been at the forefront of struggles such as those at Jantar Mantar and the Satya Niketan protests and therefore have a head start. Many university students attended the Jantar Mantar protest for educational reforms.

Issues and voting

While some students said they preferred to vote based on issues, many said they voted for friends or people they knew.

Sejal Kapoor, a first-year



Security personnel deployed to maintain law and order during the DUSU elections at North Campus on Friday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

master’s student, said she had voted, but the “throwing of pamphlets, harassment of women students and whistling” made students less interested in politics. She said, “After Jantar Mantar, many students were inspired to take a stand.”

On the other hand, Muskan, who said she goes by her first name and is a master’s student, said although she did not attend the Jantar Mantar protest, she identified with some of the issues raised there. “I am trying to appear for exams like Staff Selection Commission. When I reached 30 seconds late, I wasn’t allowed to enter. This is ironic because they themselves cancel papers and spoil the entire system,” she said.

The students, however, said such issues had barely featured in the election campaign. They also discussed which organisations had participated in the protests and which had

not, but said this was unlikely to influence the outcome of the elections.

A cleaner DUSU

A group of students from the School of Open Learning and the Non-Collegiate Women’s Education Board (NCWEB) protested for a cleaner DUSU. Jyoti, an NCWEB student associated with the Krantikari Yuva Sangathan, said, “Just a few minutes ago, a male student made lewd gestures at us. They throw pamphlets around despite the guidelines and look for reasons to touch women students. This is how the money-muscle game works here.”

Himanshi, a first-year student at Hansraj College, did not vote. “There is no point voting because nobody really raises our issues. Hostels remain shut; we have *gaushalas* (cowsheds) in college instead of hostels, but nobody speaks about this,” she said.

728 voters in Yamuna JJ cluster seek return to draft electoral roll

Suruchi Kumari
NEW DELHI



Kamal Lal has been trying to meet officials and submit grievances of the residents. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Weeks ago, long-time residents of a *jhuggi-jhopri* (JJ) cluster on the Yamuna floodplains, falling under the Bela Estate polling area of the Chandni Chowk Assembly constituency, were shocked to learn that their names would not figure in the post-special intensive revision draft electoral roll after their houses were demolished by the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) in 2023.

After the demolition, the residents continued to live at the same address in makeshift shanties and even cast their votes in the 2024 and 2025 elections. As poll officials visited for address verification on Friday, the residents said they felt a step closer to getting their names back on the electoral roll.

The pre-SIR electoral roll for the area had 729 voters, of whom 728 were placed on the ASDD (absent, shifted, dead and duplicate) list in the draft roll. According to Kamal Lal, a resident, 550 of those voters continue to live in the JJ cluster and had submitted their enumeration forms, but were still placed on the ASDD list. Of these 550 residents, 462 have now submitted Form 6 applications to be included in the electoral roll.

Proving existence

Badrinath Jha, a resident, said officials visited the area in the afternoon and called out names from at least 10-15 Form 6 applications to verify that the applicants lived there.

“Not everybody was present because some had gone to their daily-wage jobs. This is a fight to prove

our existence and our right to vote, which everyone has. And we will win it,” he said.

Mr. Lal has been trying to meet officials and submit grievances.

“During the enumeration process, Electoral Registration Officer Manoj Kumar told us that despite submitting the enumeration forms, our names would not be included in the draft roll because of the DDA demolition action here,” he said.

Mr. Lal, who retrieved electoral rolls dating back to 1962, said, “My grandfather’s name is on that roll. All our names were on the 2025 electoral roll when we were residing here. Where can we go?”

He kept photocopies of all 550 enumeration forms before handing them over to the BLO.

Mr. Lal said he was now hopeful that their names would be restored on the roll and that all the Form 6 applications would be accepted.

“We have submitted all the documents we had as address proof,” he added.

Assistant Electoral Registration Officer Sunil Kumar said, “We are verifying whatever they have submitted along with their Form 6 and doing field verification. We are also setting up camps.”

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commercial project in B.O.T
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(Sd/-) Managing Director

I, Nimish Goel, son of Mr. Amit Goel, R/o Flat No. 601, Tower KM-05, Jaypee Kosmos, Near Jaypee Hospital, Sector-134, Noida, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh - 201304, hereby state that my wife, Neha Agarwal, my son, Advik Goel, and I reside at the above-mentioned address.

I hereby permanently sever all kinds of relationships and ties with my father, Amit Goel and my mother Santosh Goel R/o South City Delhi Road, Saharanpur Uttar Pradesh. In the future, they themselves shall be solely responsible for any kind of acts or actions undertaken by them. Neither I nor my family shall be responsible for the same.
Nimish Goel

PUBLIC NOTICE



NOTICE FOR LOCKER HIRERS

This is to notify to the following Locker Hires that the "Final Notice" issued to them by courier for their in-operative locker for more than SEVEN YEARS has been returned undelivered. By this public notice, all the respective locker hirers are called upon to visit the respective branch to operate the locker on or before 19 December 2026, failing which the bank shall proceed for a "Break open" of locker without any further notice. The cost of such break open of locker shall be borne by locker hirers only.

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AUTHORISED OFFICER
DATE: 19/09/2026
REENA SHARMA

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FORM NO. INC-26

(Pursuant to rule 30 of the Companies (Incorporation) Rules, 2014)
NOTICE FOR CHANGE OF REGISTERED OFFICE OF THE COMPANY
FROM ONE STATE TO ANOTHER
Before the Central Government/ Regional Director, Northern Region, New Delhi

In the matter of Companies Act, 2013 sub-section (4) of Section 13 of the Companies Act, 2013 and clause (a) of sub-rule (5) of rule 30 of the Companies (Incorporation) Rules, 2014

AND
In the matter of Shriwika Rubber & Chemicals Private Limited having its registered office at E-54, Groy off Floor, Lajpat Nagar-II, South Delhi, New Delhi, India, 110024 (CIN: U5111DL1995PTC096330)
Pettitioner
Notice is hereby given to the General Public that the company proposes to make application to the Central Government under section 13 of the Companies Act, 2013 seeking confirmation of alteration of the Memorandum of Association of the Company in terms of the special resolution passed at the Extraordinary general meeting held on 8th September 2026 to enable the company to change its Registered Office from "Delhi" to the "Haryana" i.e. within the jurisdiction Registrar of Companies, Chandigarh. Any person whose interest is likely to be affected by the proposed change of the registered office of the company may deliver either on the MCA-21 portal (www.mca.gov.in) by filing investor complaint form or cause to be delivered or send by registered post of his/her objections supported by an affidavit stating the nature of his/her interest and grounds of opposition to the Registrar of Companies, New Delhi-110003. The address of the company is at the address mentioned below: A-15, Flee Complex Okhla, Phase-2, New Delhi-110003

For and on behalf of the Applicant
Shivika Rubber & Chemicals Private Limited
ABHISHEK GARO (Director)
DIN: 05182641
Address: E-54, Ground Floor, Lajpat Nagar-II, South Delhi, New Delhi, India, 110024
Date: 08.09.2026, Place: Delhi

PUBLIC NOTICE

PUBLIC NOTICE

FORM NO. INC-26

(Pursuant to rule 30 of the Companies (Incorporation) Rules, 2014)
NOTICE FOR CHANGE OF REGISTERED OFFICE OF THE COMPANY
FROM ONE STATE TO ANOTHER
Before the Central Government/ Regional Director, Northern Region, New Delhi

AND
In the matter of Shree Energy Buildwell Private Limited having its registered office at E-54, Groy off Floor, Lajpat Nagar-II, South Delhi, New Delhi, India, 110024 (CIN: U70109DL1999PTC09923D)

Pettitioner
Notice is hereby given to the General Public that the company proposes to make application to the Central Government under section 13 of the Companies Act, 2013 seeking confirmation of alteration of the Memorandum of Association of the Company in terms of the special resolution passed at the Extraordinary general meeting held on 8th September 2026 to enable the company to change its Registered Office from "Delhi" to the "Haryana" i.e. within the jurisdiction Registrar of Companies, Chandigarh. Any person whose interest is likely to be affected by the proposed change of the registered office of the company may deliver either on the MCA-21 portal (www.mca.gov.in) by filing investor complaint form or cause to be delivered or send by registered post of his/her objections supported by an affidavit stating the nature of his/her interest and grounds of opposition to the Registrar of Companies, New Delhi-110003. The address of the company is at the address mentioned below: A-15, Flee Complex Okhla, Phase-2, New Delhi-110003

For and on behalf of the Applicant
Shree Energy Buildwell Private Limited
SATISH KUMAR (Director)
DIN: 00246978
Address: A-15, Flee Complex Okhla, Phase-2, New Delhi-110003
Date: 08.09.2026, Place: Delhi

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, SRI Atul Dev age about 39 years S/O Niren Dev residing at No.3 Simen Chapori, P.O. Simen Chapori, P.S. Simen Chapori, Dist. Dhemaji, Assam have changed my minor daughters name from Hunjoni Devi to Jesmine Devi vide affidavit dated 02.09.2026 at Dhemaji, Assam.

PUBLIC NOTICE

PERSONAL

CHANGE OF NAME

I, RIZWAN Ul Hoda s/o Mubinul Hoda residing at T-104, Taj Enclave, Geeta Colony, Delhi, have corrected my name to Rizwanul Hoda vide affidavit (15-Sep-2026) at Delhi.

UNION TERRITORY OF JAMMU & KASHMIR
OFFICE THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER PWD (R&B) DIVISION JAMMU EAST

SHORT NOTICE INVITING TENDER
Short e-NIT No. 55 of 2026-2027 dated 16-09-2026 (4th Call)
Consultancy service (Through e-procurement mode)
(TWO COVER SYSTEM)

For and on behalf of the Lieutenant Governor, Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir, e-tenders are invited on Percentage Basis from the eligible Consultants registration with Council of Architecture (CoA) India for the below mentioned work :-

S. No	Name of Work	Approved cost of Project (in Lacs)	Adv. cost of Consultancy incl. all taxes (in Lacs)	Cost of document (in Rs.)	Earnest Money (in Rs.)	Time Allowed for Completion
1	2	3	4	5	6	7
1	Rendering Consultancy Service for providing of Architectural Drawings / Structural Design with calculations and other Civil and Electrical works incl. Soil investigation (with plate load test), Vetting of structural drawings / design from any IIT / NIT / GCET Jammu / DIQC Jammu or any other recognized Institute in India and preparation of detailed estimate for TS and BOQ on SSR rates in-vogue for tendering incl. time to time supervision of projects during execution of the project for the proposed Strengthening of Office Building of District Industries Centre, Jammu damaged in floods incl. creation of additional block.	218.13 (Main Building Cost = Rs. 166.57 Lakh	2.91	600	2% of Advertised Cost	Upto completion of project

The bidding document consisting of qualifying information, eligibility criteria, bill of Quantities set of terms and conditions of contract and other details can be viewed/ downloaded from the website www.jktenders.in as per the schedule given below

1	Date of Issue of Tender Notice	16-09-2026
2	Period of downloading of bidding documents	From 16-09-2026 to 22-09-2026 upto 1800 Hrs
3	Date, Time and place of pre-bid meeting	19-09-2026 at 1300 Hrs in the Office of Executive Engineer, PWD (R&B) Division Jammu East.
4	Bid Submission Start Date	16-09-2026
5	Bid Submission End Date	22-09-2026 upto 1800 Hrs
6	Date & time of opening of Technical (Online)	23-09-2026 on or after 1300 Hrs in the Office of Executive Engineer, PWD (R&B) Division Jammu East
7	Date & time of opening of Financial Bids online	To be notified after technical bid evaluation

Bid document s can be seen at and downloaded from the website http://jktenders.gov.in Bid documents contain qualifying criteria for bidder, specifications, bill of quantities, Conditions and other details.
Sd/-
No.: 7141-46, Dated :- 16-09-2026
DIP/J-10702/26, Sep 17 2026
Executive Engineer
PWD (R&B) Division Jammu East

GOVERNMENT OF JAMMU AND KASHMIR
DEPARTMENT OF TOURISM

Civil Secretariat, Jammu/Srinagar
Notice inviting Tenders

For and on behalf of the Hon'ble Lieutenant Governor, J&K, UT. The Director Finance, Department of Tourism, UT of J&K invites online tenders for Request for Proposal for Selection of Consultants for formulation of GIS-Based Tourism Destination Master Plan for Tourism Development Authorities in the UT of JK.

The online tender along with the scanned copy of CDR/FDR, Bid Fee and other relevant documents should be uploaded on or before 23.10.2026 up-to 5.00 PM HRS.

S/NO	RFP No	Bid Fee	EMD
1	RFP No: 02 of 2026-27 Dated 16.09.2026	Rs. 11,800.00	Rs. 15,00,000.00

1. The bidding documents can be downloaded from the website www.jktenders.gov.in
2. The bids received will be opened on 27 Oct-2026 at 2.00 PM Online.

Sd/-
Director Finance
Tourism Department
DIP/K- 5880/26 Sep 18 2026

To protest EC action, TMC withdraws from Nagaon bypoll

CM
YK

AMUL
OFFICIAL SPONSOR OF
INDIAN CONTINGENT
ASIAN GAMES
— 2026 —

As the World's No. 1 Cooperative and the World's Strongest Dairy Brand*, Amul is proud to stand behind Team India as they take on the best in the world. With a deep commitment to supporting sporting excellence, we are delighted to be the Official Sponsor of the Indian Contingent at the Asian Games 2026. Let's go for gold again!



**Amul (GCMMF) has been ranked the world's No. 1 cooperative based on GDP per capita performance, according to the International Cooperative Alliance (ICA), World Cooperative Monitor 2025 and the world's strongest dairy brand as per Brand Finance UK's Food & Drink Study 2026.*



BRS working president K.T. Rama Rao in conversation with *The Hindu*'s Political Editor Nistula Hebbar in New Delhi. SHASHI SHEKAR KASHYAP

‘Regional parties are closest to the people’s aspirations’

The BRS's focus is now on winning back Telangana, says its working president, adding that regional parties will continue to play an important role in national politics. He defends welfare schemes introduced by his party during its 10-year tenure in the State, backs Gen Z protests, questions the Uniform Civil Code and weighs in on Uttar Pradesh politics and the Opposition's role in the 2029 general election

INTERVIEW

K.T. Rama Rao

K.T. Rama Rao, working president of the Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS), spoke to **Nistula Hebbar** on national issues and those concerning Telangana.

You referred to Telangana as India's most successful start-up State. You were in power for 10 years and are now in the Opposition. What, in your view, went right and what went wrong during those 10 years?

First of all, the development model that we pursued was extremely inclusive, holistic and integrated. We increased the installed power capacity from 7,700 MW to 24,000 MW and the per capita income from ₹1 lakh in 2014 to ₹3.27 lakh, the highest in the country. We built the world's largest lift irrigation project, Kaleshwaram, within four years. We have also become home to some of the world's largest campuses of technology majors such as Amazon and host the second-largest offices of Apple, Facebook, Uber and Salesforce.



Telangana has the highest tax revenues among all States; 84% of our revenues come from our own pool. We do not depend on the Centre

But by the time we demitted office, we had the unique record of having the lowest number of farmer suicides among all States.

Even the Union government was inspired by, or copied, if I had to be blunt, several of our programmes, including our Rythu Bandhu scheme, which became the PM-Kisan Samman Nidhi. What is called the Jal Jeevan Mission today was inspired by Mission Bhagiratha, a project that we launched. Mission Amrit Sarovar, which was initiated by the Union government, was also inspired by Mission Kakatiya, our programme for the rejuvenation of 46,000 tanks.

What went wrong?

I think 10 years of anti-incumbency, a little bit of overconfidence and, most importantly, the Congress's over-the-top promises, as it was desperate to come to power in Telangana. There is a movie called *The Angrez* which has a character called *Salim Feku*. Rahul Gandhi probably outdoes the character because of the kind of fake propaganda and fake manifesto they have unleashed – 420 promises in all, bundled into the Congress manifesto, out of which they said they would deliver within the first 100 days after the formation of the government.

We still lost by only a 1.8% vote difference, but our comeback will be much bigger than before.

You mentioned Rythu Bandhu and other schemes, which you claim the Centre adopted under different names. However,



When the BJP wants to win polls, ₹10,000 in Bihar for women or ₹2,500 for women in Assam is not seen as a freebie. Theirs is a doctrine of convenience

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has also spoken about “revdi (freebies)”, over which there has been a lot of debate over the past few elections. Is there a mea culpa there for you, and what do you think is the end point of all this?

We are a developing country, or, if I have to put it bluntly, a third-world country. Having said that, many people, especially the BJP, speak of taxpayers and their burden with regard to freebies. The fact is that every citizen of this country pays taxes, directly or indirectly. People speaking of “freebies” conveniently forget that and only make the case for those in the income tax net.

In our country, whether the per capita income is \$2,700 or some other figure, I think the primary responsibility of any elected government, irrespective of its political affiliation, is first to cater to the most vulnerable sections of society.

As for the BJP, you cannot run with the hare and hunt with the hounds.

When the BJP wants to win polls in Bihar or Assam, ₹10,000 in Bihar for women or ₹2,500 in Assam is not seen as a freebie. It is a doctrine of convenience.

Our party had promised, 10 years before the formation of Telangana, that we would provide income support. Unlike others, we are not one of those fair-weather parties that switch positions as and when needed.

But what about State finances? State governments are going into debt, and a lot of these incentives are also pushing them towards that.

Debt has to be looked at in sync with GDP and growth rates. As long as you are investing in productive sectors, as long as your GDP is growing and the value of the rupee is stable, debt is good.

When we assumed office, our debt-to-GDP ratio was about 21%.

When we left, it was about 26% or 27%, subject to correction. We invested the debt we raised in building large-scale infrastructure projects.

Today, if you go back and look at the numbers, Telangana has the highest own tax revenues among all States. 84% of our revenues come from our own State pool. We do not depend on the Centre. Our average growth was about 12% over the 10 years that we governed, including the COVID-19 period.

Now, if you have that kind of growth, I think

the debt is justified, especially if you are investing in productive sectors. Every country in the world, every economy, has debt. Japan has one of the highest debt-to-GDP ratios in the world; it is more than 200%. The United States, one of the largest economies in the world, has a debt-to-GDP ratio of over 100%. India's debt-to-GDP ratio is about 59%, and for a State like Telangana, it is around 26% to 27%, which is highly manageable.

Coming to regional parties, many seem to be imploding nowadays. Do you think we are going back to a two-block party system? Also, your party changed its name from TRS to BRS, signalling national ambitions. Is that over now?

Firstly, let me talk about my party before I talk about anybody else. Yes, we did have national ambitions. But the plan was basically to take whatever we were doing to adjacent States, such as Maharashtra. With Stalin sir and Mamata *did*i, we did make several attempts, as you said, to cobble together a third alternative in the name of a federal front that was non-Congress and non-BJP. It did not succeed as we had hoped. But if a party can go from two seats in 1984 to 303 in 2019, anything can happen.

Currently, our focus is on winning back Telangana, quite frankly, not just because of the State but also because of national-level concerns.

For example, ever since the BRS lost in the Lok Sabha election, we have seen the State lose its voice in Parliament. Despite having eight Congress MPs, eight BJP MPs and one AIMIM MP, none of them has stood up for the State's interests.

As an example, let me tell you about a project called *Banaka-cherla* that the Andhra Pradesh government under Chandrababu Naidu has proposed. It is on the Godavari river and is detrimental to Telangana.

However, none of the BJP MPs from the State have raised the issue. Likewise, none of the Congress MPs from Telangana protested when BJP MP Tejasvi Surya stood up in Parliament and equated the formation of Telangana with Partition and Pakistan.

Therefore, it is clear that regional parties are much closer to the aspirations of the people. I believe that if you notice the erosion in the numbers of both the BJP and the Congress over the last 12-13 years, no single national party can form a government going ahead, since the Congress's graph is not rising proportionately to the fall in the BJP's support.

It took a stir by a completely unknown entity, the Gen Z that appeared out of nowhere, to inspire the youth of this country to rally behind it.

Your sister, former MP K. Kavitha, has left the BRS and formed her own party. How do you address this issue, especially as allegations of misogyny within the family

are being levelled?

It is wrong to say that misogyny or patriarchy guided any such decision. She chose to level some wild allegations against our own party leaders, which is absolute indiscipline. No matter who you are or what you are, you are not above the institution. It is as simple as that. At the end of the day, no individual is bigger than the institution or the political party. That is why she was suspended. It is as simple as that.

You have referred to the Gen Z protests as a kind of inflexion point in Indian politics. Now, with some distance, do you maintain that view?

Speaking as a citizen, what I witnessed in Delhi was truly heartening, since the youngsters overturned everyone's idea that they were an out-of-sync, disconnected generation. The way they demonstrated and used technology creatively was mind-boggling for those of us who have been in politics for 20 years and have seen *dharnas* and *hartals* forever.

It was an inflexion point, without question. It was not just about NEET, but about the angst of the youngsters in this country that came to the fore. And I do believe that it is going to augur very, very well for the country at large.

For the past few years, we have been seeing a ruling party at the Centre that only cared to win elections, either through *jumla* (slogans) or *humla* (attacks) via its agencies such as the Central Bureau of Investigation, Enforcement Directorate and Income Tax Department. The good thing that I observed about the Gen Z protests is that they do not care about all that, and that will be a game changer.

We may see the Delimitation Bill being tabled again. What is your view on the issue?

When the Constitution was being drafted, it was agreed that there would be a Census every 10 years and that delimitation would be carried out accordingly. That happened until 1971, when the number of seats was frozen for 30 years and family planning policies were rolled out to address the issue. Only a few States, mostly in the South, as well as Odisha and Punjab, implemented the family planning policies stringently.

As a result, today there is a disproportionate number of people in the northern belt and a smaller number in the southern States. The southern States accounted for 24% of the population in 1971; that figure is now down to 19%. If you go by population alone, you will effectively be punishing States that followed the Centre's population-control policies.

However, we are now hearing, unofficially through various sources, including journalists and friends in Delhi, that there may be a 50% increase in seats across the board. If that happens, it could help maintain the existing balance. And if representation is your only goal, then increasing the number of MLAs in State legislatures could be another route to better representation.

Home Minister Amit Shah has said that the 21 States with BJP or NDA governments are to implement the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) by 2029. What are your views?

See, the BJP has its own vision of India, but we believe that India has extraordinary diversity, even within the same religious group.



This is why I think he also said that tribal communities would be exempt from the UCC.

Also, if this is not a Central Bill and every State is to have its own version of the UCC, then how is that uniform? There are 28 States in India. If you are going to implement it in 21 and leave the remaining seven, it defeats the whole purpose of uniformity and is self-contradictory.

In the past, your MPs in the Lok Sabha took ‘neutral’ positions that helped the BJP with its legislative agenda. In hindsight, do you think it was a strategic error? And in 2029, do you intend to pick a side, seeing that the INDIA bloc has concretised?

I don't think India's politics is bipolar. In the last 80 years, India has seen some very interesting things happen, and I disagree that the INDIA bloc has concretised. In fact, if anything, it has dissipated. Where are some of the biggest partners in the INDIA bloc from the last election? Where is the TMC?

Where is Uddhavji's party? Where is the DMK? They have left the INDIA bloc.

I seriously don't see the Congress as inspiring other regional parties, mainly because of its arrogance, which does not allow it to treat the other party sitting across from it as an equal. For example, in Uttar Pradesh, mark my words, they will mess with Akhileshji again.

In fact, if they had not been with him the last time, he would have won. He lost because of the Congress. I hope that Akhileshji wins, but the Congress's arrogance and sense of entitlement are a problem.

As for our supporting or staying neutral on the BJP's legislative agenda, that doesn't mean we are with them. Even the Congress supported several pieces of legislation that the BJP brought in. Does that mean they are together?

We supported the government when some of the Bills were in sync with our ideology, for example, the Goods and Services Tax. But we also regret some things we may have done, such as the reading down of Article 370. Some of these things became contentious much later. Even demonetisation, for that matter. We supported it. We regret it today.



(From right) Former Rajya Sabha MP K.R. Suresh Reddy and Rajya Sabha MPs D. Damodar Rao and Vaddiraju Ravi Chandra during the event in New Delhi. SHASHI SHEKAR KASHYAP





No hard ceilings

A rise in minimum PF pension will protect the worse-off among the retired

The Union Cabinet’s approval to raise the wage ceiling for mandatory coverage under the Employees’ Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) from ₹15,000 to ₹25,000, though belated, is commendable. The BJP-led government has finally responded to this long-standing demand of workers in the organised sector. Around 51 lakh additional employees may be brought under the PF fold, which has around 7.98 crore contributing members. Those in the wage slab of ₹15,000-₹25,000 will now be covered under the Employees’ Pension Scheme (EPS), 2026. Although Union Labour Minister Mansukh Mandaviya cited a government survey as the basis for the increase, the 12-year delay in implementing it should have been avoided. The Minister, who said that the average salary in private establishments was ₹23,000, should also make the survey’s findings public for a better understanding of the country’s overall wage situation. With some concerns having been raised that not every employer may be willing to make the additional contributions required after the revision, the government must ensure that all employers comply with the law.

So far, the government has been silent on revising the EPS minimum pension of ₹1,000, fixed in September 2014 alongside the previous revision in the PF wage ceiling. EPFO pensioners have been demanding the hike in the minimum pension amount. Before it assumed office at the Centre in 2014, the BJP had urged the Congress-led UPA government to keep the minimum pension at ₹3,000 and index it to inflation. Yet, it has not made even a symbolic beginning towards the indexation of pension to inflation. Moreover, about 45% of the nearly 82 lakh pensioners receive ₹1,000 or less. In March 2026, the Joint Parliamentary Standing Committee on Labour reminded the government that “the existing minimum pension amount is inadequate to meet even the basic needs of pensioners particularly in the ... scenario marked by ... rising healthcare and living expenses”. Also, little is known about the follow-up to the panel’s recommendation for “an urgent and comprehensive review of the minimum pension”. The EPFO must release the findings of actuarial assessment, made by valuers in recent years. This should also be beneficial to the PF body, as EPFO CEO Ramesh Krishnamurthi observed in an interview with *The Hindu* in August that “there is a misconception that the [pension] fund has unlimited resources”, while ruling out the reopening of the window for higher pensions. Even if the government is unwilling to restore the pre-2014 coverage, under which all employees were covered regardless of their wages, it should consider relaxation of the restriction on the coverage. Else, many pensioners will be pushed below the poverty line.

Continental glory

India might get another 100-medal haul from a smaller contingent

Even as Japan, known for efficiency, welcomes its third Asian Games and the first in 32 years, on Saturday, the Aichi-Nagoya Games have already earned the ‘worst ever’ tag because of accommodation and logistical issues. A country that successfully hosted two Olympics – in 1964, within two decades of suffering atomic bombings, and in 2021, behind closed doors amid the unprecedented COVID-19 pandemic – is now strangely struggling to accommodate more than 17,000 athletes and officials from 45 nations in hotels, containers and a cruise ship. Despite these issues, 501 of India’s athletes, including 267 men and 234 women, across 36 disciplines, will try to keep its flag flying high. At the previous Hangzhou Asiad, India had an impressive tally of 106 medals and was placed fourth behind China, Japan and South Korea. There is a significant drop in the number of Indian athletes, from 650-plus in 40 disciplines three years ago, following rationalisation, discouraging a mad rush because of the perks and money associated with the Asiad. Nevertheless, Indian sports authorities expect around 100 medals, which may noticeably improve the athlete-to-medal ratio.

The presence of 310 debutants in the contingent signals a brighter future for the country, which has spent nearly ₹800 crore on Asian Games preparations in the last cycle. Shooting and athletics, which together field 105 athletes, should continue to be the major contributors to India’s medals tally, followed by archery, boxing, badminton, squash and wrestling. Stars including Manu Bhaker, Mirabai Chanu, Lovlina Borgohain, P.V. Sindhu, Aman Sehrawat, Tajinderpal Singh Toor, Gulveer Singh, Harmanpreet Singh, Smriti Mandhana and Jasprit Bumrah will lead India’s campaign. At 39, squash player Joshna Chinnappa will be the first Indian to compete in seven consecutive Asian Games. The youngest athlete, 15-year-old cricketer Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, and the oldest, 55-year-old rider Shruti Vora, are the other attractions. Some attention will also be devoted to Indian men’s and women’s hockey teams, which will aim to win gold medals and secure berths at the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics. While India can take pride in fielding athletes in debut-making disciplines, such as mixed martial arts and teqball, it should ponder over its poor representation in swimming, gymnastics and cycling, which offer more medals and open avenues for Olympic glory. Meanwhile, the Indian men and women’s teams would be watched closely in cricket. In pushing for continental excellence, India should also remain vigilant about its deteriorating global reputation due to the sharply rising doping graph.

Technologies that once arrived in India through imports are increasingly being invented at home through local research institutions, industry, and startups. Three institutional foundations of an innovation economy are now advancing together: public research, corporate research and development (R&D), and deep-tech entrepreneurship. The transformation is yet incomplete, but the architecture is finally visible. Gallium Nitride (GaN) semiconductor technologies, critical for advanced radar, space systems, and next-generation communications, are increasingly being developed domestically, helping close a strategic gap in a tightly regulated, export-controlled field. At the same time, affordable immunotherapies developed in India are expanding access to advanced cancer care and demonstrating the country’s growing capacity for biomedical innovation.

Patent filings are often cited as a ready indicator of innovation. The filing numbers continue to show impressive growth. From just over 1,10,000 patent filings in 2024-25, the number grew to more than 1,43,000 in 2025-26, a 30.2% increase. Moreover, domestic applicants now account for almost seven in 10 filings.

However, the sheer volume of applications does not tell the complete story. Even a modest enquiry reveals an innovation story that begins to fray at the edges. The number of patents in force in India (just over 2,40,000 in 2025) is a fraction of those in China (5.7 million), the United States (3.5 million), and Japan (2.1 million); all these are 2024 data.

This suggests low grant rates, high abandonment rates, or a combination of both. Add to this meagre commercialisation, low R&D spending – India still spends just under 1% of GDP on research and development, against about 2.4% in China and 3.5% in the U.S. – and we see how far we are from a truly technology-driven, innovation-led economy.

The emerging pillars

However, there lies a resilient core, and shaping it are three strong and vital strands that promise to anchor India’s future. Public institutions with government support have made vital breakthroughs in long-gestation innovation. Private R&D spending exceeded that of all levels of government combined for the first time in 2024. This is expected to climb and account for 55% through 2025-26. Domestic industrial houses are beginning to reap rewards from focused and committed R&D. A maturing startup ecosystem is finding its feet beyond low-hanging service platforms, actively showcasing deep tech and complex manufacturing. That all three strands



Mukundan Chakrapani

Holds a PhD in science and a law degree and is an academic



Gaurav Jain

Founder of Hastin Research and an intellectual property rights expert helping enterprises, startups, and universities transform ideas into intellectual property

Homegrown research and deep-tech enterprise are helping India move beyond its identity as a services provider

A homegrown innovation ecosystem is taking root

are coming of age together bodes well for India.

In March 2023, Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) scientists at the Solid State Physics Laboratory (SSPL) in Delhi and the Gallium Arsenide Enabling Technology Centre (GAETEC) in Hyderabad announced a breakthrough in making gallium nitride (GaN) monolithic microwave integrated circuits (MMICs). The technical know-how to make these circuits, which are critical for military and defence applications, was, by widely reported accounts, refused to India under the offset provisions of the Rafale fighter jet purchase from France. The DRDO is now actively transferring the technology for GaN High Electron Mobility Transistors (HEMTs)-based MMICs to be used in 5G/6G wireless infrastructure, electric vehicles on-board chargers, and renewable energy inverter systems. India is now one of seven countries to have mastered this technology, alongside China, France, Germany, Russia, South Korea and the U.S. AGNIT Semiconductors, a spin-off from the Centre for Nano Science and Engineering (CeNSE) at the Indian Institute of Science, Bengaluru is translating homegrown GaN technology to real-world commercial applications.

From implementer to innovator

While long-gestation R&D at public institutions is starting to pay off, there is growing optimism from academia and domestic industry-led R&D as well. The Bharat 6G Alliance (B6GA) is making rapid progress in its stated aim of contributing 10% of the global 6G patents by 2030. According to a review meeting by Union Minister for Communications Jyotiraditya Scindia, B6GA members have made more than 7,700 patent filings across 5G and 6G technologies, including over 4,400 foreign filings. But, these are applications, not yet grants or declared standard-essential patents, and their true impact remains to be seen. However, taken together with almost 3,000 technical contributions to 3GPP last year, a 15-fold increase from 2020, these figures point in the right direction. The World Intellectual Property Organization’s 2025 Patent Cooperation Treaty rankings showed that Jio Platforms Limited had broken into the top 20 international patent filers for the first time, rising more than 300 places to be placed 19th overall.

While patent numbers are only a part of the story, participation in standards bodies and intellectual property ownership increasingly determine who captures value from future communication networks. India is securing ownership of critical digital infrastructure and is moving from being a standard-implementer to a standard-setting innovator.

Deep-sea discovery, environmental responsibility

India is standing at the threshold of a new frontier. But the most important question is not how deep we can go, how much we can mine, or how much wealth lies beneath the ocean floor. It is more fundamental: Should everything that can be technologically exploited necessarily be exploited? The question is particularly important as India strengthens its position in deep-sea exploration and develops the scientific and technological capabilities to access one of the least understood parts of the planet.

A growing deep-sea footprint

India is not new to seabed mineral exploration and holds three International Seabed Authority (ISA) exploration contracts covering approximately 95,000 square kilometres across the Central Indian Ocean Basin, Central Indian Ridge and Carlsberg Ridge in the international seabed area. Its exploration has identified an estimated 366 million tonnes of polymetallic nodules containing nickel, copper, cobalt and manganese, alongside extensive environmental and biodiversity studies.

Under the Deep Ocean Mission, India is developing deep-sea mining technology, underwater robotics and the MATSYA-6000 human submersible, while the National Institute of Ocean Technology has tested a mining machine at depths of about 5,270 metres. At the same time, biodiversity surveys across 19 seamounts have studied around 1,300 deep-sea organisms, including nearly 23 species reported as new to science. These achievements also impose a profound responsibility to decide whether technological ability should ultimately lead to exploitation.

Technological progress can create a dangerous assumption: if we can exploit something, we should. But the deep ocean challenges this logic. It is a complex and poorly understood ecosystem, and India’s own biodiversity research continues to reveal previously unknown organisms. We cannot confidently predict the consequences of



P. Ragavan

Marine biologist with over a decade of professional experience in the conservation and management of coastal and marine environments

India has an opportunity to become a global leader not only in deep-sea technology but also in deep-sea ecological governance

large-scale seabed disturbance while our understanding of these ecosystems remains incomplete. This is not an argument against science, but for more science before potentially irreversible intervention. Deep-sea minerals may have legitimate strategic importance for India’s renewable-energy, electric-mobility and advanced-manufacturing ambitions. However, strategic importance cannot automatically become ecological permission. Before considering extraction, India should ask whether the minerals are genuinely necessary at the proposed scale, whether alternatives exist, and whether demand can be reduced through recycling, efficiency, substitution and a circular economy. Necessity must be demonstrated, not presumed.

India’s investment in deep-ocean science need not imply a commitment to commercial mining. Exploration can advance knowledge, biodiversity assessment, environmental baselines and technology without leading to exploitation. Mining, however, would physically disturb the seabed. Therefore, adaptive management alone cannot guarantee ecological protection. India has an opportunity to adopt a stronger principle before exploitation begins: the question should not be “How can we mine with minimum damage?” but “Do we need to mine at all?” Since India’s ISA activities remain at the exploration stage, this is the right time to establish a high ecological threshold for any future decision to exploit.

Science must also teach us to say ‘no’

The deep ocean is now emerging as the next frontier for economic growth. Yet, we expect the ocean to regulate climate and support biodiversity while extending industrial activity into its least understood ecosystems. The ocean should not become a place where the environmental costs of human consumption are simply relocated. Scientific progress should not mean making more of nature exploitable and

There is also a marked shift in India’s startup ecosystem. Buoyed by the government’s commitment to Research, Development, and Innovation (RDI) and private capital matched by initiatives such as the more than \$2.5 billion in deep-tech commitments made by members of the India Deep Tech Alliance (IDTA), Indian startups are aiming farther and higher than before. Pixxel Space, founded by two Birla Institute of Technology and Science (BITS) Pilani alumni, is carving a niche in hyperspectral imaging technology with six satellites in orbit and a full constellation of 18 to 24 planned. The Vikram-1 low earth orbit launch by Skyroot Aerospace and the IIT Madras nurtured Agnikul Cosmos’s parallel push towards fully reusable launch vehicles promise to strengthen India’s role as a frugal space technology leader.

Startups such as ImmunoACT, incubated at IIT Bombay in partnership with the Tata Memorial Centre, are expanding access to advanced and affordable health care. NexCARI9, India’s first indigenous CART cell therapy, has delivered effective cancer treatment at a tenth of typical treatment costs. Leveraging the Biotechnology Industry Research Assistance Council (BIRAC) early-stage support, Bengaluru-based Remidio Innovative Solutions is at the forefront in the fight against preventable blindness, such as diabetic retinopathy and glaucoma, through smartphone enabled retinal imaging systems and AI.

The direction is clear

These examples do not by themselves make India an innovation superpower but demonstrate that the three strands are coming together to weave an enduring innovation ecosystem. The GaN story illustrates the emerging innovation pipeline. Government laboratories developed the foundational capability, academic institutions nurtured the talent and research ecosystem, and startups such as AGNIT are now carrying the technology into commercial markets.

However, sustaining these three strands will demand more work, from standardising tech-transfer terms for publicly funded IP and expanding examiner capacity at the patent office, to funding the translational gap between a granted patent and a first paying customer. Yet, as we look through the innovation lens, the direction is clear. India is gradually shedding its identity as a back-office service provider and strengthening the institutions that enable nations to generate their own technology, intellectual property, and industrial capabilities. The journey remains unfinished, but the contours of an innovation economy are beginning to form.

The views expressed are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Tariff threats, diplomacy

While maintaining a robust bilateral relationship with the United States is strategically vital, foreign policy cannot be dictated by the threat of economic coercion (Page 1, “U.S. clears Russia sanctions Bill; India faces tariff threat”, September 18). True partnerships are built on mutual respect and an understanding of each other’s domestic

compulsions. Imposing 100% tariffs would not only strain India-U.S. ties but could also destabilise international energy markets, leading to wider global economic friction. India must continue its balanced diplomatic approach — diversifying its energy sources while keeping communication channels open with Washington to resolve trade frictions through dialogue

rather than compliance.
Nagarajamani M.V.,
Hyderabad

Tata’s crisis of governance

Despite the leading roles played by the Tata Group in India’s growth in semiconductors, defence, software and electronics, the recent governance crisis and boardroom divisions at Tata Sons over leadership tenure and regulatory pressures pose a systemic

risk to the broader economy. The possible legal deadlock involving the Tata Trusts and regulatory mandates could stall vital national projects, highlighting the urgent need for an amicable resolution rather than protracted feuds. This is essential both in the national interest and to uphold the reputation of the Tata name, which is held in high esteem by the

people of India.
Rajakumar Arulanandham,
Palayamkottai, Tamil Nadu

There is something quietly damning about a company that discovers the value of “leadership continuity” only when it needs to appear stable to outsiders. What this exposes is how thin the group’s commitment to its own governance standards becomes when a market debut is at stake. An

‘outgoing’ chairman’s stated principle was treated as a formality to be abandoned whenever it no longer suited investor optics. That is not stewardship. It is a company discovering, rather conveniently, that its rules mattered only until they became inconvenient.

Yashvi Patel,
Anand, Gujarat

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

GROUND ZERO



The private farmhouse on the outskirts of C.K. Tandya village that was allegedly being used as a counterfeit drug repackaging and re-labelling facility. MURALI KUMAR K.

A dangerous dose of deception

A heap of discarded medical waste near a farmhouse in South Bengaluru district led police to an alleged counterfeit drug repackaging unit and to an inter-State network supplying medicines to hospitals and clinics. The counterfeit drugs allegedly reached patients who were being treated for serious illnesses, including cancer. **Shilpa Elizabeth** and **Imran Gowhar** report on the questions raised on accountability and patient safety

In mid-August, along the Bengaluru-Mysuru expressway, an agricultural labourer in C.K. Tandya village in South Bengaluru district (formerly known as Ramanagara) noticed something unusual on a strip of farmland: a heap of medical waste.

This wasn't the first time that the villagers in South Bengaluru had noticed suspicious objects or activity around the area which contained a farmhouse, say the police. They had seen men frequently moving in and out of it on a scooter without a number plate. They had also seen courier and e-commerce delivery vehicles making regular trips to the secluded location.

Spanning nearly eight acres and fenced by a compound wall, the farmland is situated on the outskirts of the village. According to the police, the owners, who live in Bengaluru, seldom visited the place.

The villagers would whisper among themselves about what they suspected – until the day the labourer decided to report the dumped medical waste to the local beat police.

The officers at Taverekere police station put the farmhouse and the movements around it under surveillance, while also making inquiries about the property and its occupants. The people they spoke to did not seem to know anything substantial.

According to an officer, the police learned that the farmhouse had been rented about a year earlier. But what was happening inside the compound remained unclear.

Days later, the police and Karnataka's health department, in a joint operation, decided to enter the premises. What they saw there – labels, medicine boxes, drugs, and other items associated with the preparation and packaging of medicines – changed the nature of the investigation. They alerted senior officers, who joined hands with officers from the State Drugs Control Department and conducted a raid on August 18.

The police took four people into custody. They discovered that the secluded farmhouse was being used as a counterfeit drug repackaging and re-labelling facility. What began as a local's suspicion had opened the door to a much larger pharmaceutical investigation.

According to investigators, the operation involved the procurement of low-cost, substandard, or expired pharmaceutical formulations from other States, which were then transferred into fresh vials and given counterfeit labels and packaging. "The aim was to make the medicines appear as genuine products of established pharmaceutical companies and introduce them into the pharmaceutical supply chain," says a police official familiar with the investigation.

During the seizure, the police recovered more than 5,600 vials of counterfeit antibiotic injections used in treating serious bacterial infections. The total seizure was estimated at ₹4.91 crore.

They also seized ledgers, invoices, mobile phones, and other records, which provided them with details of the supply chain.

From a farmhouse to the big city

The police then moved their investigation beyond C.K. Tandya. A Special Investigation Team (SIT) was constituted.

The trail led to Bengaluru and to Krupa Healthcare, a wholesale pharmaceutical distributor located on a busy commercial street in the ci-



After my mother passed away, I started suspecting something, perhaps a nexus, but I was in no state of mind to think about it. Now I'm questioning everything.

MAHESHPRASAD UPADHYA

ty. According to the police, the operators in the farmhouse supplied medicines to Krupa Healthcare, which distributed them.

The police found that the counterfeit medicines were not limited to antibiotics, but also included critical-care injections and cancer medicines. They say some of the medicines were offered to hospitals at "discounts of up to 50%".

Krupa Healthcare owner Veeresh Kumar Jain, who was arrested by the SIT, allegedly employed more than 15 medical representatives to promote the medicines and offered commissions to push the discounted stocks to private hospitals and medical centres.

The police then found that the alleged racket was not confined to Karnataka. A joint force subsequently carried out simultaneous searches across Karnataka, Himachal Pradesh, Haryana, Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra, and Telangana. The police are currently on the hunt for Bengaluru resident R. Prashant, who they believe is a key figure in the network. He is currently in Azerbaijan, and is Jain's partner, say the police.

Unanswered questions

The families of patients are shocked and angry at these revelations. On his WhatsApp profile picture, Maheshprasad Upadhyia, 30, poses with his mother. A cervical cancer patient, she passed away in 2024. After hearing the news, Upadhyia, a native of Odisha, cannot help second-guessing the events before his mother's death.

She was diagnosed with cancer in 2022, he says. For a year, she underwent chemotherapy and radiotherapy in Mumbai. The doctors then suggested immunotherapy. As treatment in Mumbai was expensive and there were also logistical difficulties in travelling to the city, the family decided to shift treatment to Bhubaneswar.

"The doctor we consulted referred a Bengaluru-based pharmaceutical distributor to us. I bought a medicine from them. It cost ₹1,65,990 per vial. My mother needed two vials. The distributor said if we purchase one, we would get another free," recalls Upadhyia.

He searched online and found that the manufacturer did offer such a programme. He decided to go ahead with it.

Upadhyia spent about ₹20 lakh on the overall treatment. "But we saw no improvement in her condition," he says. "When she was diagnosed with cancer, the doctor had said she would live up to five years. My mother passed away in one and a half years."

Upadhyia sounds calm, but he admits within him a tumult of emotions – anger, suspicion, and



The raid at the farmhouse in C.K. Tandya village. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

helplessness. "One person who had got his father treated at the Bhubaneswar hospital had advised us against buying this medicine from this particular distributor," he says. "But we didn't listen since the doctor himself had advised it. After my mother passed away, I started suspecting something, perhaps a nexus, but I was in no state of mind to think about it. Now I'm questioning everything."

He confesses that there are times when he considers migrating abroad "after seeing how the corrupt try to profit from the desperation of the most vulnerable."

Parth Sharma, a resident of Gurugram, returned to India in 2017 to care for his ageing parents and mother-in-law, after spending 37 years abroad. "The people I came here for are no more," he says.

In October 2020, Sharma's mother was diagnosed with myelodysplastic syndrome, a condition where the bone marrow doesn't make enough healthy blood cells. The doctors informed the family that the disease was not curable. Given the patient's age – she was in her 70s – a bone marrow transplant was also not an option, they said. Nevertheless, treatment, including chemotherapy injections and blood transfusions, was started at a private hospital in December.

Sharma remembers that some of the expensive medicines were not available in India. "The doctor gave us the phone number of a person and said he would help get it imported. When you are desperate, you simply trust everyone. So, we contacted him," he says.

Sharma's mother's condition never improved. With her body too weak to fight the disease, she passed away in May 2021.

"After the report on the counterfeit drug racket came out, I started wondering more deeply about something I had suspected all along: were the medicines even working? We had spent a lot of money and given her the prescribed medicines. At that point, we trusted the system and did not even suspect the possibility of fake medicines," he says. He still has some of the tablets, which cost him around ₹80,000.

Living in uncertainty

The police say the suspect medicines have so far reached more than 90 hospitals and clinics in Karnataka and other States. While the State government has published a list of antibiotics seized during the Bidadi raid, it has not yet disclosed the names of oncology drugs or the hospitals and clinics that may have received the medicines, or the names and batch numbers of counterfeit medicines reportedly linked to serious illnesses such as cancer. There is pressure on the government to disclose this information.

According to the Karnataka Minister for Health and Family Welfare, U.T. Khader, the full list of spurious and counterfeit drugs has been communicated to the Union government and all State governments. "The SIT has taken charge of the investigation now. Once the report is finalised, we will reveal everything. We have got the list of hospitals. But when the SIT is there, it is not right on my part to disclose anything," he says.

As the SIT continues with its investigation, Upadhyia wonders what patients must be going through with the information they have. "Imagine their state of mind. Would they want to continue or discontinue treatment when they have no way of knowing whether the medicine they are taking is genuine or counterfeit," he asks.

Dr. B.S. Ajaikumar, radiation and medical oncologist and Founder and Chairman at Healthcare Global (HCG) Enterprises, says counterfeit drugs are a major problem in India today.

"I have been sounding the alarm on this for several years," he says. "Whenever somebody – say an insurance company – wants to bring drugs from outside, I don't allow it at HCG because I'm concerned it could be spurious. Any drug we purchase should come directly from the manufacturer. The authorities should also lay down stringent guidelines and ensure they are enforced. They should consult major users of oncology drugs like us, collaborate with us to develop a plan, and ensure spurious drugs don't enter the system."

Noting that cancer treatment often depends on the right drug, at the right dose, given at the

right time, Dr. Nitish Ranjan Acharya, Surgical Oncologist at Manipal Hospital, Bhubaneswar, points out that any compromise in the authenticity or quality of a medicine can directly affect a patient's treatment.

"If a patient receives a counterfeit, substandard, or expired medicine, the drug may not work as intended. This can delay disease control, allow the cancer to progress and, in some cases, affect the chances of achieving a good treatment response. The impact may be particularly difficult to identify because a lack of response can sometimes be mistaken for the cancer becoming resistant to treatment," he explains.

Dr. Acharya adds that there are more risks when the contents of the counterfeit drugs are unknown. "A drug could contain an incorrect dose, inactive ingredients, contaminants, or substances that may cause unexpected side effects. These risks can be especially serious for patients already receiving multiple cancer medicines," he notes. He also stresses the importance of appropriate storage and handling to maintain quality.

The question of accountability

The alleged racket also raises questions about what hospitals should do when patients may have already been exposed to counterfeit medicines. As S.V. Joga Rao, a lawyer who specialises in healthcare law and ethics, says, "Given the circumstances in India, a detailed investigation may take time. By that time, the spurious drugs may have found their way to patients."

According to him, hospitals need to work with investigating agencies to identify the medicines in question and their batch numbers. "If there is some kind of leeway in terms of information, the hospital has an ethical duty to inform potentially affected patients," he says.

Noting that regulatory authorities need to be mindful of Section 17B of the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, 1940, which defines a spurious drug, and Section 18, which prohibits their manufacture, sale, stocking, distribution and other related activities, Rao also points to the legal duty of hospitals to procure responsibly, verify authenticity, and detect sophisticated counterfeiting. "If there are warning signs, they need to respond to that. The duties of the hospitals and regulators operate concurrently, although they are different in nature. It is a shared responsibility," he says.

Dr. Gopal Dabade, president of Drug Action Forum, Karnataka, says, "Drug inspectors are the first line of foot soldiers, but they are not adequately equipped. Punishment for wrongdoing is also not stringent enough." He is a part of the All India Drug Action Network, a group of non-profits working to "increase access and improve the rational use of essential medicines".

Another reality is the high cost of medicines, particularly cancer drugs, which can create a parallel market for cheaper counterfeit versions. "Better access to good quality and affordable treatment is the crux of the issue," Dabade says.

Sylvia Karpagam, a public health doctor and researcher, says people must demand an accountable public health system as part of the election mandate. She also points to the responsibility of doctors, and questions the role they play in ensuring accountability within the healthcare system. "Doctors who harp about 'evidence-based practice' in allopathy go mum when such incidents occur. Other than for their own pay cheques and to oppose any form of regulation, one barely sees doctors protesting on behalf of patients," she says.

She also stresses the importance of adequate budgets, trained and sufficient staff, and regular public scrutiny. "Unless the government has an ongoing system to prevent drug rackets, and makes it known to the public through ongoing reports, these kinds of incidents will continue – some get picked up, and many don't."

SIT head C. Vamshikrishna says he cannot comment on the case while the investigation is on. Repeated phone calls and messages to reach Srinivas K. Commissioner of the Food Safety and Drug Administration, Karnataka, have not elicited any response.

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JD(U) leaders back Nishant as the future CM of Bihar

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

Janata Dal (United) leader Nishant Kumar, son of former Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, was unanimously projected as the party's future and the next Chief Minister of the State during a crucial JD(U) meeting held at the party office in Patna on Friday.

JD(U) national president Nitish Kumar, MLAs, MLCs and other senior leaders of the party attended the meeting. It was a one-day orientation and training programme for newly elected JD(U) MLAs and MLCs.

Soon after the meeting, Barauli MLA Manjeet Kumar Singh said: "There is no doubt, Nishant Kumar is our leader, and he has all the abilities to lead the party and the State. We all want him to lead Bihar in the coming days," Mr. Singh said.

Mr. Nishant did not react to his projection as future Chief Minister but rather chose to use the platform to attack the Opposition Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD).

EC should restore party symbol to Mamata: Cong.

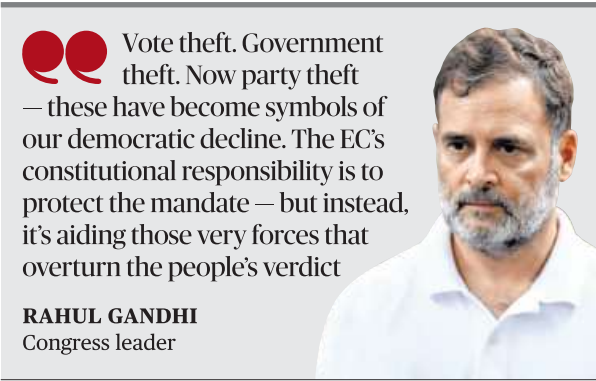
Rahul says the fight is not Mamata's alone, but that of every party and voter who wants fair polls; Venugopal terms freeze on Trinamool name, symbol as CEC's 'late-night birthday gift to Modiji'

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

The Congress has come out in support of former West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee as the Election Commission (EC) froze the name and symbol of the Trinamool Congress.

The Commission on Thursday, barred both factions – led by Mamata Banerjee and Ritabrata Banerjee, from using the party symbol and name in the Assembly bypolls scheduled for October 6 in Nandigram and Rejinagar of West Bengal.

After defecting from the Congress, Ms. Banerjee set up the Trinamool Congress, with the symbol of grass and twin flowers, about 28 years ago, in 1998. She defeated the Left Front government in the 2011 Assembly polls and served as Chief Minister of the State for 15 years, before losing to the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in the 2026 Assembly polls.



Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi criticised the EC and said that the fight is not just Ms. Banerjee's fight.

"It's the fight of every political party, every voter who wants free and fair elections," he posted on social media.

The Congress leader said that when an entire party can be stolen, it is hardly surprising that the votes of millions of Indians can be stolen too.

"Vote theft. Government theft. Now party theft – these have become

symbols of our democratic decline. The EC's constitutional responsibility is to protect the mandate – but instead, it's aiding those very forces that overturn the people's verdict," he posted on social media platform X.

Mr. Gandhi recalled that first it was Shiv Sena, then NCP, and now Trinamool Congress. "Every time, the same pattern – BJP and the Election Commission join forces to split a party. Then its election symbol is snatched away," he said.

Congress general secretary (organisation) K.C. Ve-

nugopal, in a social media post, condemned the move and demanded that the EC immediately restore the party symbol to Ms. Banerjee.

'EC's gift to Modi'

"Freezing the AITC name and symbol – after a blatantly unconstitutional hijack by the BJP – is CEC Gyanesh Kumar's late-night birthday gift to Modiji. Those who fought against the BJP, under Mamata Banerjee's leadership, are now being given the red carpet to rebel against her and commit the unconstitutional sin of defection with the EC's help," Mr. Venugopal said.

Observing that whoever opposes the BJP is dealt a fatal blow and their entire electoral existence is snatched away from them, the Congress leader said that the EC has once again proven that it is nothing more than a puppet in the hands of the BJP – a tool to destroy democracy bit by bit.

Congress betrayed allies, sidelined veterans: BJP

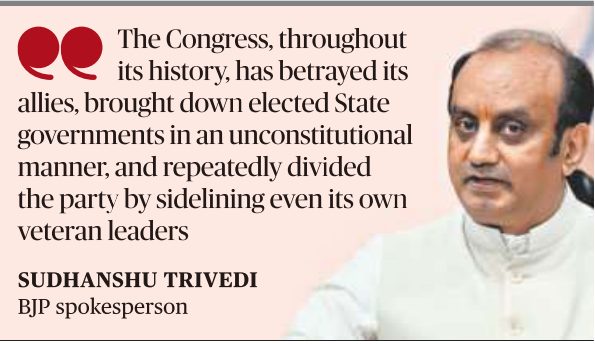
The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

In response to Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi's allegations of "government theft" and "party theft" after the Trinamool Congress symbol freeze, the BJP on Friday said the Congress's history was replete with instances of "betraying allies and bringing down elected governments".

The Election Commission had barred two factions of the Trinamool from using the existing party symbol and name, and allotted them fresh symbols and names for use in the coming Assembly bypolls.

BJP MP and spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi described the Congress as the "Bhasmasur" of Indian politics, alleging that whoever came in contact with it was eventually destroyed.

At a press conference, he said that "the Congress, throughout its history, has betrayed its allies, brought down elected State governments in an unconstitutional manner, and repeat-



edly divided the party by sidelining even its own veteran leaders", while the BJP was "a symbol of democratic values and unity".

"Rahul Gandhi cannot even read enough to understand that the full form of NCP is 'Nationalist Congress Party' and that the name of the Trinamool Congress also contains the word 'Congress'. Sharad Pawar separated from the Congress in 1999 over the issue of leadership by a person of foreign origin, while Mamata Banerjee left the party in 1997 after being distressed by the internal situation within the Congress, and later ousted the Congress itself from West Bengal," Mr. Trivedi said.

He accused the Congress of sidelining and undermining several people, including its own leaders, over the years. "...in the 1969 Presidential election, Indira Gandhi called for votes against her own party's candidate, Neelam Sanjiva Reddy", said the BJP leader.

He further alleged that senior Congress leader Ashok Gehlot was recently "prevented from becoming Congress president". "The betrayal of Chaudhary Charan Singh during the Janata Party regime, the merger of the Lok Dal in Haryana in 1980, and the absorption of Chimanbhai Patel's Janata Dal into the Congress in 1992" were among the alleged instances he cited.

Secularism is a 'modern' concept, does not fit India's tradition, says RSS chief

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) chief Mohan Bhagwat on Friday cautioned young people against getting consumed by ego, saying the belief that everything is under one's control and should happen according to one's wishes is a misconception.

"Take the example of the sun. Even if you do not believe in the sun, it will still rise and set," Mr. Bhagwat said while speaking at the 'Yuva Dharma Sansad' in Ujjain, Madhya Pradesh.

He added that people should not live under the illusion that everything op-



Mohan Bhagwat

erates according to their control and highlighted that "if there is a rise, there will also be a fall".

Regarding the definition of secularism, the RSS chief termed it a modern concept that does not fit India's traditional under-

standing of the relationship between religion, society and the state.

He said India's approach has traditionally been based on non-discrimination and equal respect for different religious paths.

Mr. Bhagwat also urged young people to respect their own chosen form of worship while showing equal respect for the practices of others.

Sharing his understanding of the Western concept of secularism, the RSS chief said it emerged from a historical conflict between kings and religious authorities. "...there was a conflict between kings and religious authorities over

who should have power. After much bloodshed, a compromise was reached which was that the king would look after this world, and the religious authorities would look after the other world. So, secular came to mean the material or worldly sphere," he said adding that India's tradition seeks both material prosperity and freedom from anger, greed and jealousy, viewing life holistically through dharma. Hence "secular does not fit the Indian context", he said, claiming that "whenever India was governed by Indians, the country followed the path of dharma".

Congress disputes panel chairperson's claim on its MPs supporting UPI MDR

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Friday contested Parliamentary Standing Committee on Finance chairperson Bhartruhari Mahtab's reported assertion that Opposition members had supported the panel's recommendation to explore a merchant discount rate (MDR) on high-value UPI transactions, calling the claim "erroneous and fallacious".

Congress MP Manish Tewari, a member of the committee, said the suggestion that Opposition members had endorsed the proposal by not recording a dissent was "un-

founded and unfortunate".

"With great respect, this is both erroneous and fallacious and therefore facetious," Mr. Tewari said, referring to the BJP MP's assertion that the Congress MPs on the panel endorsed the move.

Only to 'explore'

Responding to reports quoting Mr. Mahtab as saying that the presence of Opposition members and their participation in the panel's report were matters of record, Mr. Tewari said the committee's recommendation was only to "explore" a revenue model for sustaining the UPI ecosystem. "The core of the com-

mittee's recommendation... is as follows: 'The Committee recommend that while the proposed 3-year multi-year scheme and cash back components are necessary to democratise digital payments in untapped Tier 3-6 cities, the Department of Financial Services must concurrently explore a self-reliant, tiered revenue model,' he said in a post on X.

Mr. Tewari said the government's subsequent action-taken report, laid in the Lok Sabha on August 12, similarly stated that the Department of Financial Services was "currently exploring" two options – restoring MDR for certain

high-threshold transactions and adopting a tiered incentive structure to phase out government support.

"The key word is 'explore'," he said, adding that the proposal to actually levy a transaction fee on digital payments had never subsequently come up before the committee.

Congress general secretary-in-charge of communications Jairam Ramesh, tagging Mr. Tewari's post, said Mr. Mahtab was "otherwise a seasoned and sober Parliamentarian but is 2024 Batch Odisha cadre of the BJP". "This explains his eagerness to mislead and misinformation," he said on X.

Cong. targets PM over CBI probe against Arunachal CM

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Friday questioned Prime Minister Narendra Modi's silence over the Supreme Court-ordered preliminary CBI inquiry into allegations of irregularities in the award of public works contracts worth about ₹1,270 crore to firms linked to the family members of Arunachal Pradesh Chief Minister Pema Khandu.

Congress general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh said Mr. Khandu should have resigned, or have been asked to resign, after the Supreme Court directed the CBI to conduct a preliminary inquiry into the matter.

"But both the CM and his Supreme Leader the PM decided to brazen it out," Mr. Ramesh said in a post on X.

He said the Supreme Court, on August 24, had noted that instead of providing the relevant documents, the State government had supplied "huge chunks of documents" to the CBI. "It is extraordinary and totally unacceptable that the CM continues in office..." he said.

JPC members question Centre on FCRA Bill's asset takeover provisions

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

At the first meeting of Parliament's Joint Committee on the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, members raised a barrage of questions on the proposed changes. The thrust of the ruling party MPs' queries was on the utilisation of foreign contributions, while Opposition members questioned provisions dealing with assets when an organisation's FCRA licence is cancelled.

The Opposition objected to the provision relating to the "designated authority", which will have a wide ambit of powers. Under the provision, if an organisation's FCRA certificate is cancelled, surrendered, or lapses automatically, foreign contributions and all assets created from them would vest in a government-appointed "designated authority", without a prior hearing or judicial determination.

The Union Home Ministry, in its submission, said the proposed amendments are aimed at making the use of foreign contributions more transparent and accountable.



Opposition MPs protest against the FCRA Bill during the Budget Session of Parliament in April. ANI

The Ministry representatives also argued that the provision for a "designated authority" is not new to the law. Under the existing legislation, there is a provision for a "prescribed authority", which, according to a notification issued on November 5, 2018, is the Additional Chief Secretary or Principal Secretary (Home) of the concerned State or Union Territory.

However, under the current law, there is no deadline for such custodianship, leaving the "prescribed authority" as a "passive custodian" unable to take "substantive decisions on assets".

There is also no standard procedure for taking possession of such assets,

maintaining inventories or segregating foreign-contribution assets from domestically funded ones, the Ministry said in its submission, according to sources.

Officials further argued that in cases of prolonged custodianship, States may face budgetary and manpower constraints in managing vested institutions such as schools, hospitals and orphanages. The existing law is also silent on the final disposal of assets and the treatment of places of worship, they said.

According to sources, several Opposition members, including the DMK's P. Wilson and the Trinamool Congress's Menaka Guruswamy, argued that

deprivation of property cannot be permitted without a prior hearing under Article 300A of the Constitution. The Home Ministry's presentation also came under fire for cataloguing foreign contributions received by different religious groups and highlighting that a majority of the funds were received by Christian organisations.

Members questioned the Ministry's rationale for segregating contributions received under religious heads.

'National security law'

The FCRA was enacted in 1976 at the height of Cold War geopolitics, amid deep mistrust of Western influence and heightened sensitivity regarding threats to India's sovereignty and democratic institutions. Prior to 1976, the NGOs receiving foreign funds operated under general laws such as the Societies Registration Act, the Trusts Act and the Companies Act, with no centralised mechanism to monitor foreign contributions.

Citing this backdrop, the Home Ministry said the latest amendment is, at its core, a "national security" legislation.

GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA - DEPARTMENT OF WATER RESOURCES OFFICE OF THE CHIEF CONSTRUCTION ENGINEER, KANUPUR IRRIGATION PROJECT AT/PO-BASUDEVPUR, DIST-KEONJHAR, ODISHA, PIN-758047 e-mail: ccekippbur@gmail.com	
"e"- PROCUREMENT NOTICE - Bid Identification No. CCE, KIP (KCB-D-12/2026-27)	
(Pertaining to Kanpur Canal Division-I, Jhumpura)	
1. Name of the Work	As per Detailed Tender Call Notice
2. Total No. of Package	03 (Three Nos. of individual Work)
3. Estimated Cost	221.86 to 543.04 Lakh
4. Period of completion	As per Detailed Tender Call Notice
5. Class of Contractor	"B" or "A" Class Contractor as per Detailed Tender Call Notice
6. Date & Time of availability of bid document in the portal	Dt.21.09.2026 from 10.00 Hours to Dt.05.10.2026 up to 17.00 Hours.
7. Last date / Time for receipt of bids in the portal	05.10.2026 up to 17.00 Hours.
8. Date & Time of Opening of Tender (Technical Bid)	07.10.2026 at 11.00 Hours
9. Name and address of the Officer Inviting Bid	Er. Mahendra Kumar Behera Chief Construction Engineer, Kanupur Irrigation Project, At/Po.- Basudevpur, Dist.- Keonjhar, Odisha - 758047.
Further details can be seen from the e-Procurement portal "https://www.tendersodisha.gov.in" (Er.Mahendra Kumar Behera) Chief Construction Engineer, Kanupur Irrigation Project, Basudevpur, Keonjhar, Odisha	
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NOTICE INVITING TENDER CPD/46 - 2026 - 27		
Tenders are invited through e-Tendering in SRM Two Bid system from the registered vendors for Supply of following:		
Tender No. & Description of Material	Estimated Amount (in Rs. Lakhs) (Inclusive of all Taxes)	Due Date & Time (Hrs.) for Submission & Opening of Tender
	Tender Fee (in Rs.)	
SP/T-0708/0926 [2 nd Call] (RFX No. 7000041595) for Procurement & Installation of Centralized Visual Advance Monitoring System (CVAMS) at various EHV S/s. (total 100 Nos.- 400kV, 220kV & 132kV) in MSETCL along with establishment of Centralized Control & Monitoring Centre at MSETCL, Mumbai & integration of existing installed as well as proposed CVAMS at various S/s in MSETCL	Rs. 8570.95 Lakhs	28.09.2026 12:00 Hrs
	25000.00 +GST	28.09.2026 12.30 Hrs
Contact Person: Office of the Executive Engineer (Gr-VII) CPA, C.O. MSETCL, 1st Floor, Prakashgad Building, Bandra (E), Mumbai Tel. No.: 022-69852712/ 69852720 Email id: cecpa@mahatransco.in, secpa@mahatransco.in, eegrp8@mahatransco.in, eepe@mahatransco.in. For further details visit our website https://srmetender.mahatransco.in/ Any further amendments / clarifications will be published on the MSETCL website www.mahatransco.in & https://srmetender.mahatransco.in/. Bidders are therefore requested to check these websites for further updates.		
Sd/- Executive Engineer (P&C)		

INBRIEF



Indian-born cheetah gives birth to four cubs at Kuno

An Indian-born cheetah has given birth to four cubs in Madhya Pradesh’s Kuno National Park, months after her previous four cubs were killed in a leopard attack. The latest litter has taken the total population to 56. Union Minister for Environment, Forest and Climate Change Bhopender Yadav announced the latest litter, on X, which comes a day after India’s Project Cheetah, the reintroduction programme for the big cat species, turned four. Speaking to *The Hindu*, Kuno Field Director and Project Cheetah Director Uttam Kumar Sharma said the four cubs appeared to be healthy and a team was keeping a watch without disturbing the mother the cubs.

UGC-NET results for re-test of three papers announced

The National Testing Agency on Friday declared results for re-test of UGC-NET papers for English, commerce and sociology. The NTA last month announced the re-test for the three papers of the UGC-NET June 2026 examination following complaints about several errors in these papers. “UGC NET June 2026 Examination Results Declared for English, Commerce, and Sociology. Candidates can view and download their score cards through the official website,” the National Testing Agency (NTA) said in a post on X. The English and the commerce paper were held on September 9, while the sociology paper was held on September 10.

3 held in J&K for ‘providing logistical support’ to terrorists

Three local persons were held in Pir Panjal valley’s Rajouri district on Friday for allegedly providing logistical support to infiltrating terrorists of the Lashkar-e-Taiba in the region, the Jammu and Kashmir Police said on Friday. “The three accused persons were allegedly part of a logistic support module linked to the proscribed terrorist outfit LeT,” they said. The arrested persons were identified as Mohammad Azam, Zakir Hussain and Mohammad Mushtaq, the police said, adding that the accused allegedly “harboured and facilitated the movement of terrorists”, and “provided shelter and logistical assistance to multiple terrorist groups”.

Tulu to get official language status in coastal Karnataka

Fulfilling a long-pending demand of the people of coastal Karnataka, the State government in its Cabinet meeting in Mangaluru on Friday decided to accord the additional official language status of the State to Tulu, widely spoken in Dakshina Kannada and Udupi districts. Making this announcement after the Cabinet meeting, Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar said the status would be applicable for administrative matters in Dakshina Kannada and Udupi districts while the respective district administrations would be the implementing agencies. The government would release ₹82 lakh annually for translation, training and language usage purposes, he added.

Shift to computer-based NEET-UG under ‘active consideration’: Centre

Nilekani-led task force may submit report by September-end; SC asks when reforms will be implemented on ground; it says NTA should have structural stability through permanent offices and half of its workforce must be permanent employees

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

After the 2026 question paper leaks and with NEET-UG, 2027 just months away, the Union government told the Supreme Court on Friday that a switch from the written examination to computer-based mode was still under “active consideration” and “something will have to be done”.

Appearing before a Bench of Justices P.S. Narasimha and Alok Aradhe, Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta, who also represents the National Testing Agency (NTA), was responding to a petitioner’s argument that the government must clarify the examination mode for NEET-UG, 2027.

Mr. Mehta responded that both the government and the High-Powered Task Force chaired by Infosys co-founder Nandan Nilekani were “cognisant” of the issue. “It is nearing the next exam. Something will have to be done. It is under active consideration,” Mr. Mehta stated. The court directed the Nilekani task force to file an affidavit



Nearly 23 lakh students had registered for NEET-UG, 2026, which was scarred by controversy after a paper leak. FILE PHOTO

within two weeks. Towards the end of the hearing, Justice Narasimha remarked that reforms would “take about a year to become entrenched... Filling up of posts, various verticals, specialised personnel, infrastructure, digitisation, transition from written to digital exam”.

The NTA has been under the Supreme Court’s scanner since the 2026 leaks, which left nearly 23 lakh students stranded, led to protests and violence in the national capital, and, ultimately, the resignation of the then Education Minister.

The task force was formed by the government to recommend technologi-

cal reforms to make the conduct of public examinations under the NTA leak-proof.

Earlier CBT proposal

In May 2026, an NTA affidavit confirmed that the agency was ready to change to the computer-based test (CBT) mode the following year. The agency had noted that a High-Level Committee of Experts (HLCE) had recommended the move.

“The transition will be implemented from the next examination cycle in consultation with the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare (the client Ministry for NEET-UG) – thereby bringing all major NTA ex-

aminations onto the CBT platform,” the affidavit had said.

More recently, the government and the NTA were of the opinion in court to take the “final approach” to CBT mode only after considering the recommendations of the Nilekani task force. Mr. Mehta said the task force may submit the report by the end of September 2026. The top law officer said the Nilekani task force had already held consultations with the chairman of the High Powered Steering Committee (HPSC) on NTA Reforms, Dr. K. Radhakrishnan. The HPSC had been constituted earlier to suggest measures for a comprehensive “clean-up” of systemic issues haunting the conduct of NEET-UG examinations.

“But we are still concerned. Today, there are only committees. When are their recommendations going to be implemented on the ground?” Justice Narasimha asked the law officer.

Mr. Mehta agreed that the Nilekani committee was only the “starting point” on the road to re-

forms. Justice Narasimha said the judges intended to come to the NTA offices personally to monitor its functioning. “We will come there one day. Myself and my brother. We will come and see if the system is actually working, whether there is enough manpower... We will drop in and see,” Justice Narasimha said.

The court said the NTA should have structural stability through permanent offices and staff. At least half of its workforce must be permanent employees rather than deputed officials.

The court said that the senior leadership must be drawn from diverse specialised services to build strong institutional memory, ensuring that the reforms persist even after officials are transferred out. The Bench said consultations with domain experts were an essential part of reform. The court recorded in its order that the NTA was “transitioning from exam-specific units to functional vertical structure to build specialised domain-specific capabilities across core operational areas”.

CBI registers fresh case against RCAP, Anil Ambani

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has registered a fresh case against Reliance Capital Ltd. (RCAP), its former chairman Anil Ambani, and others, alleging that they caused a loss of ₹2,684.57 crore to the Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC).

The first information report (FIR) also names Satish Seth as the then group managing director of Reliance Anil Dhirubhai Ambani Group, besides unknown public servants and others.

In its complaint, the LIC said that from April 12, 2012, to March 9, 2018, it subscribed to five non-convertible debentures (NCDs) aggregating ₹3,900 crore issued by RCAP for general corporate purposes, funding requirements, and refinancing of existing debt.

According to the CBI, the accused persons caused a wrongful loss of ₹2,684.57 crore to the LIC and corresponding wrongful gain to themselves and other beneficiaries. It alleged that they dishonestly induced the LIC to invest in RCAP through misrepresentation and thereafter fraudulently diverting the said funds.

Marathi film *Gondhal* is India’s pick for Oscars 2027

Press Trust of India
MUMBAI

Marathi film *Gondhal* has been chosen as India’s official entry to the Oscars 2027, the Film Federation of India announced on Friday.

Written and directed by Santosh Davakhar, the film is set in rural Maharashtra and plays out over a night of a traditional ritual centred around a newlywed couple.

The film was chosen as India’s submission for Best International Feature category for the 99th Academy Awards from a list of 33 films, said P. Sheshadri, chairperson of the selection committee.

“This year we’ve had four Marathi films, 14 Hindi films, and other films, all the films were good. It’s a happy moment for Indian cinema, for Marathi cinema. This time the official



A still from *Gondhal*. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

entry is *Gondhal*,” Mr. Sheshadri said at a press conference here.

“We’ve watched 33 films in last 10 days of different languages. There were many other good films for which we were debating about. *Angh* and *Ikis* were in top three list apart from *Gondhal*,” he added.

“*Gondhal* had its world premiere at the 56th International Film Festival of India (IFFI) in Goa in 2025 in the Indian Panorama segment. Davakhar won the

Silver Peacock for Best Director at the festival.

Set against the midnight carnival of the ritualistic Gondhal dance in rural Maharashtra, the movie follows Suman, a woman trapped in an oppressive marriage, who plots a murder and an escape with her forbidden lover, blurring the lines between devotion, deception and fate.

No Indian winner so far
No Indian film has managed to win in the Best International Feature film segment so far, which was earlier known as the Best Foreign Film category.

Only three Indian films have received nominations in the category – Mehmood Khan’s *Mother India*, Mira Nair’s *Salaam Bombay* and Ashutosh Gowariker’s *Lagaan*.

The 99th Oscars will take place on Sunday, March 14, 2027.

HAL hands over two LCA trainer plane to Air Force

Hemanth C.S.
BENGALURU

A handover ceremony of various military and civil rotary wing aviation along with pilot training platforms developed by Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL) was held in Bengaluru on Friday. Defence Minister Rajnath Singh and Union Minister for Civil Aviation K. Ram-mohan Naidu were present.

HAL handed over two Light Combat Aircraft trainers to the Indian Air Force (IAF), completing the twin seater deliveries under the Final Operational Clearance contract. HAL said that the twin seaters are intended to facilitate the graduation of trainee pilots from the twin-seat platform to fighter aircraft.

Four Dhruv Next Generation helicopters were also handed over to Pawan



Rajnath Singh, K. Rammohan Naidu, Air Chief Marshal A.P. Singh, and others during the handing-over ceremony in Bengaluru. PTI

Hans Ltd., marking the induction of the civil-certified Dhruv NG into the civil aviation segment. The Dhruv NG is a 5.5-tonne, light twin-engine, multi-role helicopter developed by the HAL to address demanding operating conditions in India and has been upgraded for the requirements of the global civil aviation market.

The Hindustan Turbo Trainer-40 (HTT-40), a basic trainer aircraft intended to meet the primary train-

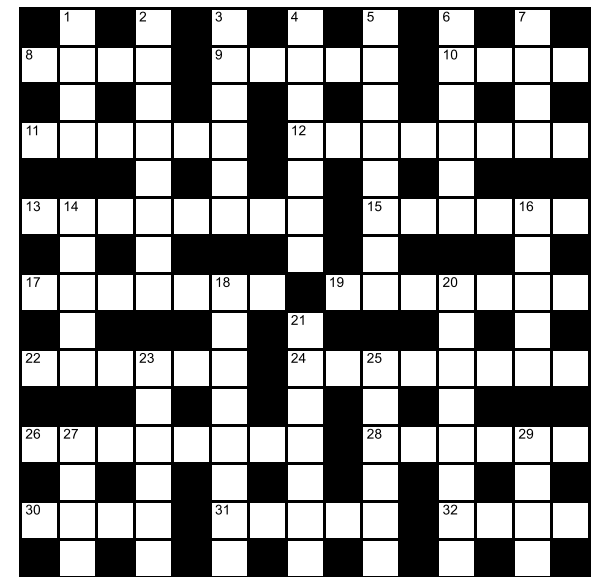
ing requirements of the Indian defence services, was also handed over to the IAF. The HTT-40 aircraft is designed to support multiple stages of basic pilot training, including aerobatics, instrument flying, and navigation.

Mr. Singh called for realistic project timelines to address delays in ongoing projects. He added that there was no need to view public and private sectors as competitors but to look at them as collaborators.

THE CROSSWORD+ 14902
(set by Incognito)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

SCAN TO PLAY



- 15 Spiritual session from Connery at church (6)
- 17 Setter and that lady from London wander in a circuitous manner (7)
- 19 A testing facility by American Medical Association in state (7)
- 22 Search for a forge under construction (6)
- 24 Last amulet broken up carried note (8)
- 26 Steer one vehicle in reverse at entrance (8)
- 28 Editor cooked bile that can be consumed (6)
- 30 Wealthy! Having lots of oil! (4)
- 31 Beats in places for social gathering (5)
- 32 Bird nesting in winter nest (4)
- Down
- 1 In short, Mansoor Ali Khan's love for shark (4)
- 2 Islander's god placed under rug protected by local star (8)
- 3 Setter leaves mini-bike damaged in island (6)
- 4 Chivalrous girl with trainee soldier (7)
- 5 Huge lasso thrown by colonel (8)
- 6 Ali had dissected flower (6)
- 7 Food from Kentucky (4)
- 14 Belief in sacred order (5)
- 16 Celestial visitor comes endlessly... with a bit of tail (5)
- 18 Cheap, yet extraordinary device useful for dressing up as a pirate (8)
- 20 Meet by accident? (4,4)
- 21 Exclude and lure (4,3)
- 23 Get off! It's on fire! (6)
- 25 Tiny nest built around eastern yard (6)
- 27 Letter in Arabic from Halifax (4)
- 29 To some extent strangely restless, one has to be plucky to play this instrument (4)

- Across
- 8 Graduate at King University in capital (4)
- 9 State: I had returned with nothing (5)
- 10 Fever from time covering youth centre (4)
- 11 African rode out from ladies' room agitatedly (6)
- 12 Resemble John Kelvin and be attracted to (4,4)
- 13 Dangerous creature from No.1 Corps, perhaps (8)

SUDOKU

						8	5	
	3	8	1		6	9		
	9			5	3			
							3	
4		9		6		5		7
	2							
			2	3			4	
		4	7		5	8	1	
1	7							

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

Solution to previous puzzle	Solution to yesterday's Sudoku
A T O U G H F I G U R E S I A T R D A N I M A T E E T E S U R M I T A G G O R E D I O N E D I G I T R H M T A N Y T I M E T I N W E A V E N N N N E N E P C H A T E A U G U A R A N I S A M B A P R I L S E M P A C O W P A R L E M E N T M A N C H E S T E R U N I V E R E E S S E N U E A R C H A E O L O G I S T	7 2 1 8 5 4 9 3 6 6 4 8 9 3 2 7 1 5 3 9 5 6 7 1 2 8 4 5 7 2 1 6 9 8 4 3 8 6 9 3 4 5 1 7 2 4 1 3 7 2 8 5 6 9 9 8 4 2 1 3 6 5 7 1 5 7 4 9 6 3 2 8 2 3 6 5 8 7 4 9 1

FAITH

Fix the mind on Krishna

One is always advised to examine something that comes very easily in life, since nothing is easy to get in this world and to have a higher purpose. Considering that it is human nature to centre all our actions around the human body, we find it difficult to disown everything in this world and focus only on God. One should not worry if one has the mentality to handle the vagaries of worldly life, since Lord Krishna says to not worry about it, but surrender to Him. One should place one's mind in Krishna and believe that He will uplift us, said Swami Sivayoganandha.

Krishna is just a hand stretch away, if one can develop the bhakti the right way. There are many ways to reach Him and it is possible to try one of them. In order to attain the goal, one should prepare oneself. How? In Chapter 12, verse 8, Krishna says, “Fix your mind upon Me alone. After that, you will be within me, without doubt.” In order to do that, one should align both the mind (emotions) and the intellect. The two are two sides of a coin and while one side might want God, the other would want only God. It is not enough to place an idol or an image in one's puja room; one should place Him in one's mind and see the world through Him. Krishna assures the devotee that when the mind is thus fixed upon Him, the devotee will remain with Him always, not merely in the present and the future, but beyond that as well.

One of the astounding aspects of the human mind is its ability to determine intention, especially when it comes to worldly matters. It is fine to ask Krishna for various things in life. However, one should have the determination and the wisdom to pray to Krishna saying, “I need You.”

INBRIEF



NSE's ₹22,569-crore IPO fully subscribed on Day 2

The mega ₹22,569-crore initial public offering of the National Stock Exchange of India (NSE) was fully subscribed on the second day of bidding on Friday, driven by encouraging response from qualified institutional buyers and non-institutional investors. The NSE IPO received bids for 8,88,23,000 shares against 8,86,42,911 shares on offer, as per data available with the BSE till 2:56 PM. The category for Qualified Institutional Buyers (QIBs) was subscribed 1.32 times, while the non-institutional investors portion garnered 1.37 times subscription. The retail investors quota received 66 per cent subscription. The offering is India's second-largest public issue after Hyundai Motor India's ₹27,870-crore IPO in 2024. PTI

'MDR apprehension unlikely to spur higher cash usage'

Concerns that introducing a Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) would spur a surge in cash transactions are unlikely to materialise, RBI Deputy Governor Shirish Chandra Murmu said on Friday, adding that it was only an "initial apprehension". "I don't think that apprehension will come true," he addressing a financial market conclave. "Because it is a major shift in terms of how basically you are recovering the cost. So, that's why it may be apprehension only. I don't think this will have any impact, unlike some voices about whether cash will go up because of this MDR." On the apparent paradox of rising digital transactions and cash in circulation, Mr. Murmu said there was no paradox as cash serves both as a means of transaction and a store of value. "This cash paradox, actually, that is not my work. That is the way media has read it, and analysis has read it. Because it points towards data," the Deputy Governor said. PTI

Higher advance tax mop-up boosts net direct tax collection by 13%

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The government's net direct tax collection rose 13% to more than ₹12.12 lakh crore till September 17 in the current financial year, buoyed by better advance tax mop-up from corporates, data released by CBDT on Friday showed. Advance tax mop-up grew 16.2% to about ₹5.22 lakh crore. This includes an 18% growth, at over ₹4.16 lakh crore, in advance tax payments by corporates, and a 9.24% rise in non-corporate advance tax of ₹1.06 lakh crore.



Gross direct tax collection clocked 15% growth.

Refunds jumped 29.2% to over ₹2.2 lakh crore till September 17 as per the Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) data. Gross direct tax collec-

tion clocked 15% growth, totalling over ₹14.32 lakh crore. After adjusting for refunds, net collections from direct taxes (including corporate, non corporate, STT) grew 3% to over ₹12.12 lakh crore.

The government has budgeted to collect Rs 26.97 lakh crore from direct taxes in the current financial year, a 15% growth over Rs 23.40 lakh crore collected in FY26.

Corporate tax mop-up
Net corporate tax mop-up rose 19.5% to about ₹5.56 lakh crore, while non-corporate tax (individuals and

HUFs) mop-up rose 6% to over ₹6.16 lakh crore. Securities Transactions Tax (STT) collection grew 53% to ₹40,214 crore between April 1 and September 17.

Deloitte India partner, Rohinton Sidhwa said the over 50% rise in STT mop-up seems to be primarily driven by rate hikes in the Budget rather than a rise in turnover. A 150% hike was effected in STT rates on equity futures, effective April 1, 2026. AKM Global managing partner Amit Maheshwari, said the trends were broadly consistent with the underlying momentum in economy.

Dr. Reddy's to market Takeda's dengue shot in India in H1-2027

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Takeda's dengue vaccine Qdenga is expected to be available in India in the first half of 2027. Dr Reddy's Laboratories and Japan's Takeda Pharmaceutical Company announced on Friday the signing of a distribution pact under which Dr Reddy's will distribute the vaccine across India's private market for pediatric and adult vaccination. "Subject to the completion of applicable processes with local authorities, the vaccine is anticipated to become available in the first half of 2027," the companies stated. Qdenga is India's first approved dengue vaccine.

In July, it got marketing authorisation from the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation for those aged 4-60. Inclusion in India's public immunisation programme remains an important long-term ambition.

Huge challenge
Dengue is a significant public-health challenge in India with reported cases surging 11-fold over the past two decades. As per a study by the Virus Research and Diagnostic Laboratory of ICMR, all four dengue virus serotypes are co-circulating across multiple regions in India with one in 14 patients being infected with multiple dengue serotypes concurrently, the companies said

L&T eyes \$30 billion modularisation deals over five-year period

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Larsen & Toubro Ltd. (L&T) is positioning to capture a larger share of the global modular construction market, as rising labour costs and shortage of skilled workers push project developers towards factory-built modules for complex infrastructure and energy projects.

The engineering and construction firm estimates the addressable global market for modularisation at about \$150 billion over the next five years, eyeing an almost \$20-30 billion share of the pie.

"Modular concepts will be popular going forward," said Subramanian Sarma, DMD and president, L&T,

adding the firm is also exploring greater adoption of modular construction in India while developing hybrid models combining modular and conventional construction to address transportation challenges.

Australian project
L&T's focus on modularisation gained speed after the successful completion of fabrication and delivery of 110 modules weighing about 64,000 metric tonne for Project CERES, Australia's largest urea making unit with 2.3 million tonne per annum capacity. The modules were fabricated at L&T's modular fabrication facility near Chennai over 30 months and shipped to Australia through 23 voyages.

'SP Group supports Tata Sons listing'

Welcoming the RBI's decision to reject 'Tata Sons' application to surrender its registration and directing the company towards necessary compliance at the earliest, Shapoorji Pallonji Group Chairman says the regulator has provided full clarity

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Shapoorji Pallonji Group Chairman Shapoorji Pallonji Mistry said he 'wholeheartedly' welcomed the Reserve Bank of India's decision with regard to Tata Sons and supported its listing "for the sake of transparency, accountability, fairness and responsible institution-building."

"The Reserve Bank of India has provided full clarity. Tata Sons had been classified as an upper layer NBFC under the RBI's scale-based regulatory framework, and the prescribed listing route followed from that regulatory



architecture," Mr. Mistry said in a statement. "With the RBI having rejected the application to surrender its registration and directing Tata Sons towards necessary compliance at the earliest, the path forward is clear," the SP Group Chairman said. Stating that the 'landmark' decision should not be viewed as a victory of

The listing of Tata Sons can become a bridge... between shareholders and Trusts, between private heritage and public accountability

one stakeholder over another, he said it should be viewed as an opportunity to bring people and institutions together. "The listing of Tata Sons can become a bridge. A bridge between shareholders and Trusts, between private heritage and public accountability, between generations of stewardship, and between India's

great past and the extraordinary future that lies ahead," Mr. Mistry said. He said a transparent and publicly accountable Tata Sons could strengthen the entire ecosystem, broaden participation, enhance governance, give greater visibility to value, protect the legitimate interests of investors and provide the basis for a more robust and equitable dividend policy. "Most importantly, it can strengthen the capacity of the Tata Trusts to pursue their philanthropic responsibilities over generations," he stated. "The millions of Indians who have invested in listed Tata companies are also part of this larger story.

They have placed their faith and their savings in the Tata name," Mr. Mistry said. "A publicly accountable holding company can strengthen the relationship between that enormous community of investors and the institution whose success underpins the wider Tata ecosystem. Transparency, in my view, is the truest form of respect for both legacy and the future," he pointed out. Calling upon every section of the Tata Group to come forward in a spirit of harmony and shared purpose, he said the listing should not be allowed to become even a minor point of division.

India Deep Tech Alliance invests ₹2,170 crore in 56 firms

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The India Deep Tech Alliance (IDTA)'s members, which include individual and corporate investors from India and abroad, invested ₹2,170 crore in 56 deep-tech firms in India over the last year, the grouping announced at the Semicon India 2026 event. The investments were made "independently by individual IDTA members in accordance with their respective investment strategies and processes," it said. Principal Scientific Adviser to the government Ajay Kumar Sood said the investments showed that the "vision" behind the ₹1 lakh crore Research, Development and Innovation (RDI) scheme of the Department of Science and Technology was "beginning to translate into measurable action". "The RDI Scheme and industry-led initiatives can complement each other in strengthening the pathways through which promising technologies move from the laboratory to the market and create long-term strategic and economic value for India," Mr. Sood said. Energy and climate-related start-ups got over 30% of the capital, with eight firms receiving ₹655 crore. Quantum, robotics and space start-ups received nearly a similar share, split among 21 companies. AI received nearly 30%, with 16 firms receiving ₹639 crore.

RBI may deliver two rate hikes by end of CY26, say analysts

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) is likely to raise the repo rate twice by as much as 50 basis points by the end of December 2026 in line with global tightening cycle and excess liquidity in the banking system. Analysts expect the Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) to deliver a 25 basis point rate hike in October 2026, followed by another 25 basis point increase in December, taking the benchmark repo rate to 5.75% by the end of the ca-



The MPC is expected to deliver a 25 bps rate hike in Oct. 2026.

lendar year. One basis point is equal to one-hundredth of a percentage point. The anticipated tightening comes amid concerns that inflation could exceed

the RBI's earlier projections, particularly if crude oil prices remain elevated. "Incoming data suggests inflation is likely to overshoot those projections. If crude prices stay elevated in the \$90-\$110/barrel range, the pass-through from producer costs to final output prices is likely to accelerate," Systematrix Group said in a report. "Against the prevailing 5.25% repo rate, it effectively implies a negative real policy rate - precisely the "cheap money" condition we had warned was unsustainable," it added.

FSSAI initiates legal action against Nestle

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) on Friday said it has initiated legal action against Nestle India Ltd. for alleged non-compliance with food safety norms in three infant nutrition products. According to FSSAI, it examined NAN Excella Pro Stage 1, Lactogen Pro I, and a follow-up formula along with their promotional material available on e-commerce platforms. In NAN Excella Pro

Stage 1, the regulator flagged claims relating to "SHMOs" and "Whey Protein," while in Lactogen Pro I, it observed a claim describing "Whey Protein" as easy to digest. FSSAI sought clarifications from Nestle India. **Nestle's response** Meanwhile, Nestle India said its infant nutrition products are "fully compliant" with all applicable regulations and that the labels of NAN Excella Pro and Lactogen Pro were approved by an expert committee of the FSSAI.

Rail Vikas Nigam Limited
(A Government of India Enterprise)
Web: www.rvnl.org, E-mail: info@rvnl.org
CIN: L74999DL2003GOI118633

EXPRESSION OF INTEREST
Eol No.:RVNL/BD/Eol/2026/02
Executive Director/Business Development on behalf of Rail Vikas Nigam Limited invites Expression of Interest (Eol) from Indian Companies having proven experience in execution of Highways, Bridges, Tunnels, Marine & Port Works, Buildings, and other Infrastructure Works, willing to associate with Rail Vikas Nigam Limited (RVNL) as Contractors/Sub-contractors for execution of projects in India.
EOI Submission cut-off Date and Time : 15/10/2026 up to 15:00 Hrs.
For further details and updates, please visit <https://rvnl.org/active-tenders>. Any amendments or corrigenda, if issued, will also be hosted on the same website.
Baldev S Jaryal - (Executive Director/Business Development)

KALOJI NARAYANA RAO UNIVERSITY OF HEALTH SCIENCES, TELANGANA, WARANGAL

Notification for Admission into BHMS course under All India Quota (Private Homeopathy affiliated colleges) for the Academic Year 2026-27
Applications through online are invited from NEET-UG-2026 qualified candidates for admission into BHMS course under All India Quota (Private Homeopathy affiliated colleges) from **06.00 AM on 19-09-2026 to 02.00 PM on 25-09-2026**. For detailed notification and Prospectus refer to <http://knruhs.telangana.gov.in>
Date :18/09/2026 5d/-
DIPR R.O.No.550-PP/CL-AGENCY/ADVT/2026-27 Dt:18-09-2026 REGISTRAR

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PARADIP PORT AUTHORITY e-TENDER CALL NOTICE
No.CE/PHD/ACCTS-14/25/312
Dtd. 09.09.2026

Name of the work: "M/R to Water Treatment Plant and Raw Water pump houses at Balijhara Water Works".
Estimated cost : Rs.1,06,00,421.62
Last Date & time of submission: 05.10.2026 up to 18:00 Hrs.
Refer our website for details : eprocure.gov.in/eprocure/app
Executive Engineer, PHD, PPA
PPA/PR/27/2026-2027, dt.18/09/2026

SPECIAL BUILDINGS DIVISION – II PUBLIC WORKS DEPARTMENT, PUDUCHERRY

No.08/PW/SBD-II/DB/D4/Tender/2026-27 Puducherry, the 18.09.2026
PRESS NOTICE FOR e-Tender e-Tendering Notice Inviting Bid Through RFP
On behalf of the President of India, Bids are invited for "Consultancy services for preparation of Conceptual drawings, Structural design & Detailed Project Report for Upgradation / Construction of Model Schools in the U.T. of Puducherry (Puducherry, Karaikal, Mahe & Yanam)"
Bid Security : Rs.1,00,000/- (Rupees One lakh only)
Period of Completion : 105 days (including Monsoon period)
Last time & date of submission of tender : 27.10.2026 at 3.00 P.M
For further details, please refer the website www.pudutenders.gov.in.
from **10.00 A.M on 23.09.2026**.
No. 207/DI/ADI/Press/2026-27
EXECUTIVE ENGINEER

PUNJAB STATE POWER CORPORATION LTD.
(Regd. Office PSEB Head Office, The Mall, Patiala)
Corporate Identification Number : U40109PB2010SGC033813
Website : www.pspcl.in (Contact number 96461-22952)

Tender Inquiry No.05/2026-27/PWMDI **Dated : 17.09.2026**
Dy. Chief Engineer / PWs & MDI Circle, PSPCL, E-4, Shakti Vihar, Patiala, invites short term e-tender for the work of Manufacturing,stacking, curing and testing of 52400 no. 9m long & 5120 no. 11m long PCC Poles at Pilot Workshop, PSPCL, Sri Muktsar Sahib.
For detailed NIT & Tender specification please refer to <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in> from 20.09.2026 02:00 PM onwards.
Note: Corrigendum and addendum, if any will be published online at <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in>.
C 897/26 **1079/12/2026-27/15371**

APPOINTMENT

इण्डियन ओवरसीज़ बैंक Indian Overseas Bank
Central Office, 763, Anna Salai, Chennai - 600002
RECRUITMENT OF GENERAL MANAGER – IBU (IFSC BANKING UNIT)

Indian Overseas Bank, a leading Public Sector Bank with headquarters in Chennai having geographical presence all over India and abroad, invites applications from **eligible candidates from Public / Private / Foreign Banks** for the captioned recruitment process. The detailed advertisement regarding eligibility such as Age, Qualification, Experience & Other requirements are available in the Bank's website www.job.bank.in under "Careers" page. APPLY ONLINE.
ONLINE REGISTRATION: 19.09.2026 – 05.10.2026 (BOTH DAYS INCLUSIVE)

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER, P.W.D. DISTT.DN.II, UDAIPUR

No.: 863 Date: 15.09.2026

Notice Inviting Bid No.12/2026-27
NIB No.:PWD2627A2759

Bids for DMFT Road/Bldg, Maintenance Works, ML/NP Yr. 2026-27 etc. are invited from interested bidders upto 22.09.2026 11.00 AM to 05.10.2026 4.00 PM. Other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal ("<http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>") and ("<http://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in>") of the state, and department website. The approximate value of procurement of **5 work** is **Rs. 396.68 Lacs.**
1. UBN No. :PWD2627WSOB12266 2. UBN No. :PWD2627WSOB12267
3. UBN No. :PWD2627WSOB12268 4. UBN No. :PWD2627WSOB12269
5. UBN No. :PWD2627WSOB12270
(Anil Khichi)
Executive Engineer,
PWD Distt.Dn.II, Udaipur
DIPR/C/16112/2026

BHARAT DYNAMICS LIMITED
(A Govt. of India Enterprise, Ministry of Defence)
GACHIBOWLI, HYDERABAD - 500 032

Ref:BDL/CC/OT/01/2026-27 Dt : 19.09.2026
e-PROCUREMENT ABRIDGED TENDER NOTICE
Inviting Indigenous Competitive Bidding

Sl. No.	Tender ID	Description	Estimate in Rs. lakhs
1	67141	Develop and Host online Web based Application and (or) Conduct online Computer Based Test	590

Please visit website <https://bdltenders.abcpocprocure.com>, select online tenders on dashboard for further details. Bids should be submitted online only, "corrigendum if any shall be issued through our e-portal only and not in Newspapers"
"Bidders are Requested to apply for online Vendor Registration in BDL website <https://bdl-india.in/online-vendor-registration> Prospects."
DEPUTY GENERAL MANAGER (Corp Comm)

कार्यालय अतिरिक्त मुख्य अभियन्ता, सार्वजनिक निर्माण विभाग, संगम, अजमेर

क्रमांक-अमुप/अज/सक/एफ-2(30ए) निविदा/बी-1852 दिनांक-15.09.2026

निविदा सूचना संख्या 20 वर्ष 2026-2027

राजस्थान के राज्यपाल महोदय जी और से फोर ब्रह्मातीकेशन पद्धति के अनुसार सड़क निर्माण कार्य हेतु उपयुक्त श्रेणी में सार्वजनिक निर्माण विभाग राजस्थान में घोषित सूचकको एवं कंठवीर / राज्य सरकार व उनके अधिकृत संगठनों / कंठवीर लोक निर्माण विभाग / डाक एम्प दूर संचार विभाग / रेवे इत्यादि में घोषित सूचकको, जो कि राजस्थान सरकार के विभिन्न श्रेणी के सूचकको के सम्बन्ध में, से निम्नलिखित प्रश्न में नुस 01 कार्य, विभिन्न कुल लगत राशि रु. 2175.87 लाख है, के लिए ई-टेंडरिंग प्रक्रिया हेतु ऑन लाइन निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती है।

निविदा कार्य डाउनलोड एवं अपलोड करने की तिथि: 16 सितम्बर, 2026 को प्रातः 9.30 बजे से रात्रि एवं समय दिनांक 07 अक्टूबर, 2026 को सांय 6.00 बजे तक।

निविदा से संबंधित समस्त विवरण वेबसाइट www.dipronline.org पर एवं निविदा दस्तावेज का विवरण वेबसाइट <http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in> एवं <http://sppp.raj.nic.in> पर देखा जा सकता है। सम्पूर्ण निविदा प्रक्रिया <http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in> पर ऑनलाइन सम्पादित की जायेगी।

NIB No.:- PWD2627A2724
UBN No.:- PWD2627WLOB12059
अतिरिक्त मुख्य अभियन्ता, सा.नि.वि, संगम, अजमेर।
DIPR/C/16056/2026

GENEVA
Yemen conflict displaces 1,12,000 people inside country, says IOM



At least 1,12,000 people have been displaced inside Yemen within the last two weeks as fighting continues along the country's west coast, while nearly 3,000 have fled to Djibouti, the International Organisation for Migration said. UN agencies described the latest fighting as being a crisis on top of multiple crises. REUTERS

KARACHI
Pakistan court blocks expulsion of Afghan medical college students



A Pakistan court blocked an order by the country's medical board for Afghans studying to be doctors to be expelled from colleges and universities and sent home. "The Lahore High Court has extended the stay order preventing the expulsion of over a hundred Afghan medical students," a Lahore court decision said. AFP

HENRICO
Early voting begins in several U.S. States as part of midterm elections



In-person voting for November 3 midterm elections began on Friday in Virginia, Idaho, Minnesota and South Dakota in the U.S., ushering in the final six weeks for Americans to decide which party they trust to lead Congress. Officials insist elections remain secure despite federal scrutiny and redistricting changes affecting millions. AP

WASHINGTON
Assad-era Syrian official jailed for 60 years by U.S. court for torture



Samir Ousman Alsheikh, a former Syrian government official who headed the Damascus Central Prison under ousted President Bashar al-Assad and was convicted of torture by a U.S. federal jury has been sentenced to 60 years in prison by a U.S. judge, federal prosecutors said. REUTERS

Russia begins three days of voting in first wartime parliamentary poll

The ruling United Russia party, backed by President Vladimir Putin, is expected to retain overwhelming control of the 450-seat Duma; any meaningful political competition has been removed from ballot with the support of nation's top court

Associated Press
MOSCOW

Russians on Friday began three days of voting in the country's first wartime parliamentary election, which features virtually no opposition and is all but certain to secure the Kremlin's political dominance. Authorities spread the election over the weekend, ending on Sunday, in a bid to boost turnout among the 111 million eligible voters, and they even allowed electronic balloting. The Kremlin wants the parliamentary election – the first since the start of the full-scale invasion of



Predetermined choice: An elderly man votes in parliamentary election at a polling station in St Petersburg in Russia on Friday. AFP

Ukraine in 2022 – to underline public support for the war and give a veneer of legitimacy to its action. It has sought to avoid any political risks by stamping

out even the slightest sign of dissent. "Your choice and resolve will once again demonstrate that millions of people stand behind our

fighters, that we are a united people, bound by shared values, historical memory, and love for the Motherland," President Vladimir Putin told the nation before the vote. Russian state news agencies reported that Mr. Putin voted online on Friday and released a video of him in front of a computer screen. The main Kremlin party, United Russia, is all but assured to retain its overwhelming control of the lower house, the State Duma. Several smaller parties of the "systemic opposition" that vote in sync with the government on all key issues also are expected to retain their presence.

Voters cast two separate ballots, filling half of the Duma's 450 seats by selecting political parties listed on the ballot. The rest are contested in single-seat constituencies, with voters choosing individual candidates. The liberal Yabloko party, the only registered political entity that dared to criticise the war, was removed from the ballot last month by Russia's Supreme Court, and only has a few dozen candidates in the single-constituency races. Additionally, some anti-war politicians have been imprisoned or forced to flee abroad ahead of the campaign.

Thousands attend Iran's government-organised rally

Associated Press
CAIRO

Hundreds of thousands of Iranians rallied on Friday in a government-organised show of defiance after months of war, pledging their readiness to take up arms in the biggest such demonstration since the United States and Israel attacked in February. Iran's government has sought to rally the people and stress national unity, even as the economy worsens under a U.S. naval blockade of Iranian ports and new U.S. sanctions. Estimates varied of the number of people volunteering to receive limited military training and defend the country in an effort described as *Janfaday-e Iran*, or the "ones who sacrifice their lives for



A woman carries a rifle as she marches with other armed women and children during a military-style parade in Tehran on Friday. AP

Iran". They marched through downtown Tehran in combat uniform, carrying flags, as onlookers cheered. For days, state media have encouraged Iranians to join the campaign, saying training with assault rifles would begin soon. The volunteers would be an additional layer of security to

the paramilitary Revolutionary Guard and the Basij militia, which has played a key role in quashing anti-government protests. Tehran's Guard chief, General Hassan Hassan-zadeh, said that over 600,000 people had registered to participate, with over one million expected to take part in the training.

China's ship 'rammed' vessel in South China Sea, says Philippines

Agence France-Presse
MANILA

The Philippines said a China Coast Guard ship "rammed" one of its fisheries department boats on Friday in contested waters in the South China Sea. China's coast guard subsequently blamed the actions of the Philippine vessel, which it said "bears full responsibility for the incident". The incident took place near a shoal in the contested Spratly Islands chain, a fish-rich flashpoint that has been the site of violent confrontations with China Coast Guard vessels in recent years. Beijing claims most of



Damaged railings on the port side of BRP Datu Magat Salamat after a collision. AFP

the South China Sea despite an international ruling that its assertion has no legal basis. The Chinese vessel "rammed BRP Datu Magat Salamat... as it carried out its maritime patrol to deliver fuel subsidy to our fishermen", Philippine Coast Guard spokesperson said.

Iran's Revolutionary Guards say they hit oil tanker in Hormuz

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN

Iran's Revolutionary Guards said on Friday they struck an oil tanker in the Strait of Hormuz, according to state news agency IRNA, as a British maritime agency also reported an attack. Iran has maintained its stranglehold on the strategic strait as Washington continues pressing its counter-blockade of Iranian ports during the West Asia war. The Islamic republic wants to charge ships for passage, attacking vessels it accuses of attempting to circumvent its preferred route.

"The Togo-flagged oil tanker *Trend* had been targeted and detained after a fire broke out on board" late on Thursday, the statement said, calling it an attempted "illegal passage". "Unknown projectile" Early on Friday, the United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations (UKMTO) said a ship was hit by an "unknown projectile", causing a fire that was extinguished. The monitoring agency had also reported a "security incident" in Hormuz late on Thursday, without giving details. It was unclear if the IRGC and UKMTO reports referred to the same incident.

Hundreds of civilians, prisoners suffer sexual abuse in Ukraine war, says UN

Agence France-Presse
GENEVA

Hundreds of civilians and prisoners have been subjected to sexual violence and torture – overwhelmingly by Moscow's forces – since Russia invaded Ukraine in 2022, the UN reported on Friday. The UN Human Rights Office attributed 89% of the documented cases to "Russian authorities – including members of the armed forces, the prison service and the national security service". It blamed the remaining 11% on "Ukrainian authorities", saying both countries should investigate promptly and bring perpetrators to justice.



Ukrainians hold photos of their missing relatives as they watch freed Ukrainian soldiers arrive in the Chernihiv region of Ukraine. AP

"Some 1,004 cases of sexual violence were documented from February 24, 2022, when Russia's attack on Ukraine began, through to the end of July this year," the UN agency said in a report. "Sexual violence has

been used against civilians and prisoners of war (POWs) in Ukraine in a shocking pattern of torture, intimidation and coercion," it said. The 20-page report is based on confidential interviews "with hundreds of

victims and survivors of sexual violence committed by both parties", as well as court documents and official records. "Alarming reports" "I am deeply alarmed by the prevalence of these abhorrent acts documented in our report, and fear that they are almost certainly continuing amid the unceasing violence we are witnessing every day in Ukraine," UN High Commissioner for Human Rights Volker Turk said. The youngest rape survivor the UN documented was a four-year-old girl and the oldest an 82-year-old woman. It blamed both cases on Russian authorities.

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Weekend Sport



GETTY IMAGES

Rags to riches – how Ollie Robinson plotted his way back from cricketing wilderness

The 32-year-old pacer spent more than two years outside the England Test set-up, with his fitness, pace and attitude all under a cloud. However, in a stunning turnaround, the swing and seam exponent has come charging back, helping England win four Tests this summer, and three of them with Player-of-the-Match performances.

Tarun Shastry

The official social media handle of the England and Wales Cricket Board recently crowned a ‘King’. Alongside videos celebrating his exploits, it declared – ‘New Ball King’.

Crowns, especially in England, are not handed out on a whim. They demand performances befitting royalty. This summer, one man has done just that, turning successive matches into his own royal procession – Ollie Robinson.

The road to royalty, however, has been anything but straightforward for the 32-year-old all-rounder. Before this summer, Robinson had last worn the England whites more than two years ago, against India in Ranchi in 2024, an outing where his returns were so meagre that he was banished from the English national cricketing scene.

Had it coming

The writing, though, had been on the wall for a while. Robinson’s fitness was a concern, dating back to the 2021-22 Ashes, before his back trouble resurfaced during the 2023 home season.

Then came Ranchi. A back spasm while batting was followed by 13 wicketless overs, with his pace at one stage dipping below 70mph. England



Just got the love of the game back, really. It’s only in the last few months that I’ve got the enjoyment back

OLLIE ROBINSON

had seen enough.

The then bowling coach Jon Lewis had made clear what Robinson needed to do. “If he’s going to perform consistently over a long period at this level, he’ll need to be a fitter bowler,” Lewis had said.

Robinson hardly helped his cause off the field either. During the same India tour, a podcast he hosted with his now spouse revealed behind-the-scenes details from the England camp, prompting the management to have the episode taken down.

While the England door remained firmly shut, Robinson went about rebuilding his career with Sussex. He helped the County earn promotion in 2024, and continued to pile up the wickets the following season.

Significantly, by the start of 2026, Sussex had entrusted him with something England never thought he could handle – the role of a leader.

Elevated to red-ball captaincy, Robinson embraced it. Sussex won three of its opening five County Championship matches, while the skipper led from the front with 17



wickets and 305 runs. There was even a back-to-the-wall, unbeaten century at No. 10 against Surrey at The Oval.

Rekindling the fun

The transformation, however, was not merely about wickets and runs. A winter spent playing grade cricket for Sydney University in Australia in late 2025 had helped Robinson rediscover his love for the game.

“Just got the love of the game back, really,” Robinson said during his comeback Test at Lord’s versus New Zealand this June. “It’s only, probably, in the last few months that I’ve got the enjoyment back. And knuckled down a bit more.”

It was a long way from where his mind had been a few months earlier. Around Christmas, Robinson had virtually resigned himself to the possibility of his England chapter being over. “I thought at Christmas time I was never playing for England again,” he admitted.

But he knew that if there was to be another chance, there was only one way of earning it. “As much as I obviously want to play for England again, I need to take wickets and rip up trees to receive that call,” he told *Wisden* before the season.

And rip he did, with the ball, the bat and as a leader.

The then red-ball head coach Brendon McCullum certainly took note. “We said bang the door down, and through the weight of performance in County cricket he has banged the door down,” gushed the Kiwi.

Striking gold

At Lord’s against New Zealand, Robinson needed all of six balls to remind England what it had been missing.

The first two deliveries of his return passed without incident. The third trapped Devon Conway in front. Two balls later, Kane Williamson



We said bang the door down, and through the weight of performance in County cricket, he has banged the door down

BRENDON MCCULLUM

lobbed one to short-leg for a duck before Rachin Ravindra was pinned down for a leg-before. A triple-wicket maiden – some way to announce a comeback!

Robinson was not done yet. To his five for 39 in the first innings, he added two wickets in the second, and chipped in with a valuable 29 with the bat as England completed a 115-run victory.

He missed the next two Kiwi Tests, the first owing to injury and the next because of non-selection. But the three Tests against Pakistan turned the comeback into a statement.

Robinson made the Dukes cherry swing, seam and dance both ways even as he used his height and high release-point to extract steep bounce.

There was the wobble-seam delivery that would hold its line, the nip-backer that would dart in, and the full inswinger. Pakistan was left bamboozled.

England added another little twist to the plan – Jamie Smith standing up to the stumps to stop Pakistan batters from venturing on adventures down the pitch, allowing the seamer to keep at-tacking the stumps.

It began at Headingley with the very first ball of the series as Robinson trapped Azan Awa in front. His five for 51 was followed by three for 29 as England romped home by an innings and 103 runs.

Relentless

Lord’s brought no respite for Pakistan. Robinson’s first five-over spell cost just six runs before he returned for another seven overs that went for only four and fetched four wickets. Four for 11 in the first innings; another four in the second; England had the series in the bag. Three Tests into his return. Three Player-of-the-Match awards.

Edgbaston merely extended Pakistan’s torment. Robinson’s three for 15 in the first essay included his 100th Test wicket before he swapped ball for bat and cracked a 47-ball 50. Then, back with ball in hand, he removed Saim Ayub first delivery and Abdullah Shafique three balls later.

Pakistan eventually found a way to blunt him, but it was a little too late as England completed an eight-wicket victory and a 3-0 sweep. Robinson had 21 wickets from the three fixtures at a mind-boggling average of 8.76 and an economy rate of 2.04.

Numbers, though, told only half the story.

The 32-year-old’s skill was never under question. It was whether his body and mind could sustain the rigours of the highest level. McCullum had put it rather plainly: “When his pace drops to 75, 76mph and the threat diminishes, he is not the same bowler.”

There, perhaps, was the difference.

The Robinson who laboured through Ranchi at under 70mph had returned fitter, happier and clearer in the mind. The height and movement were the same. The control was still there. But now, he had the body to keep it all going. The result was 28 wickets from four Tests and England’s Test Player-of-the-Summer award.

There will be tougher examinations. The Dukes will refuse to dance to his tune sometimes; conditions will not always favour him; better batting line-ups will find ways to get runs off him.

But for a man who spent more than two years out in the cold, Robinson has certainly turned up the heat this summer. Nine months since that contemplative Christmas, he is the No. 3 bowler in the world.

“The hard work’s not done yet. We’re just getting started,” said Robinson. More coronations in store? Time will tell.

STACKING UP



English Premier League Standings

#	Team	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	PTS
1	Arsenal	4	4	0	0	8	1	7	12
2	Manchester City	4	4	0	0	8	2	6	12
3	Leeds United	4	2	2	0	7	3	4	8
4	Hull City	4	2	2	0	5	2	3	8
5	Brighton	4	2	1	1	13	5	8	7
6	Chelsea	4	2	1	1	10	9	1	7
7	Brentford	4	1	3	0	7	4	3	6
8	Liverpool	4	1	3	0	6	4	2	6
9	Everton	4	1	3	0	5	3	2	6
10	Ipswich Town	4	2	0	2	7	10	-3	6
11	Nottingham Forest	4	1	2	1	4	4	0	5
12	Newcastle United	4	1	2	1	7	8	-1	5
13	Manchester United	4	1	1	2	7	7	0	4
14	Sunderland	4	1	1	2	3	5	-2	4
15	Bournemouth	4	0	3	1	6	7	-1	3
16	Crystal Palace	4	1	0	3	6	11	-5	3
17	Tottenham Hotspur	4	0	2	2	0	5	-5	2
18	Fulham	4	0	1	3	4	7	-3	1
19	Aston Villa	4	0	1	3	1	7	-6	1
20	Coventry City	4	0	0	4	0	10	-10	0

Italian Serie A Standings

#	Team	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	PTS
1	Roma	4	4	0	0	12	1	11	12
2	Inter	4	4	0	0	13	6	7	12
3	Como	4	3	1	0	9	4	5	10
4	Lazio	4	3	1	0	6	3	3	10
5	Cagliari	4	3	0	1	4	2	2	9
6	Milan	4	2	2	0	7	4	3	8
7	Frosinone	4	2	1	1	7	4	3	7
8	Juventus	4	2	1	1	6	4	2	7
9	Sassuolo	4	2	1	1	8	7	1	7
10	Napoli	4	2	0	2	6	5	1	6
11	Atalanta	4	2	0	2	5	5	0	6
12	Lecce	4	2	0	2	5	7	-2	6
13	Udinese	4	1	1	2	8	10	-2	4
14	Torino	4	1	0	3	4	7	-3	3
15	Florentina	4	1	0	3	5	11	-6	3
16	Bologna	4	0	1	3	2	5	-3	1
17	Parma	4	0	1	3	2	6	-4	1
18	Monza	4	0	1	3	6	11	-5	1
19	Genoa	4	0	1	3	2	8	-6	1
20	Venezia	4	0	0	4	4	11	-7	0

Spanish LaLiga Standings

#	Team	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	PTS
1	FC Barcelona	6	6	0	0	28	6	22	18
2	Real Madrid	6	5	0	1	17	6	11	15
3	Real Betis	6	5	0	1	8	6	2	15
4	Atlético	6	4	1	1	14	6	8	13
5	Sevilla	6	4	1	1	9	6	3	13
6	Alavés	6	3	1	2	11	6	5	10
7	RC Deportivo	6	2	3	1	9	7	2	9
8	RCD Espanyol	6	2	1	3	9	7	2	7
9	Athletic Club	5	2	1	2	7	6	1	7
10	R. Racing Club	6	2	1	3	11	16	-5	7
11	Rayo Vallecano	6	2	1	3	10	15	-5	7
12	Real Sociedad	6	2	1	3	6	11	-5	7
13	Osasuna	6	2	1	3	5	12	-7	7
14	Villarreal	6	1	2	3	10	11	-1	5
15	Levante	5	1	2	2	7	9	-2	5
16	Getafe	6	1	2	3	3	7	-4	5
17	Celta	6	0	4	2	3	6	-3	4
18	Valencia	6	1	1	4	2	10	-8	4
19	Málaga	6	0	3	3	3	11	-8	3
20	Elche	6	0	2	4	8	16	-8	2

German Bundesliga Standings

#	Team	GP	W	D	L	GF	GA	GD	PTS
1	Freiburg	3	3	0	0	10	1	9	9
2	Dortmund	3	3	0	0	8	2	6	9
3	Augsburg	3	2	1	0	9	3	6	7
4	Bayern Munich	3	2	1	0	7	2	5	7
5	RB Leipzig	3	2	0	1	9	3	6	6
6	Elversberg	3	2	0	1	8	7	1	6
7	Leverkusen	3	1	1	1	8	5	3	4
8	Mainz	3	1	1	1	6	3	3	4
9	Frankfurt	3	1	1	1	7	8	-1	4
10	Werder Bremen	3	1	1	1	5	6	-1	4
11	Schalke	3	1	1	1	3	3	-1	4
12	Cologne	3	1	1	1	5	7	-2	4
13	Hoffenheim	3	1	0	2	6	7	-1	3
14	VfB Stuttgart	3	1	0	2	6	8	-2	3
15	Paderborn	3	0	1	2	4	4	-1	1
16	Union Berlin	3	0	1	2	4	10	-6	1
17	Mönchengladbach	3	0	0	3	3	12	-9	0
18	Hamburg	3	0	0	3	0	12	-12	0



ATP Men’s Top 15

#	Player	Age	Points	Events
1	Jannik Sinner	25	11,500	17
2	Alexander Zverev	29	9,690	20
3	Carlos Alcaraz	23	5,560	17
4	Ben Shelton	23	4,680	22
5	Félix Auger-Aliassime	26	3,890	22
6	Daniil Medvedev	30	3,770	24
7	Flavio Cobolli	24	3,720	26
8	Frances Tiafoe	28	3,380	22
9	Alex de Minaur	27	3,300	24
10	Taylor Fritz	28	3,175	22
11	Arthur Fils	22	3,150	18
12	Novak Djokovic	39	2,980	16
13	Learner Tien	20	2,755	22
14	Rafael Nadal	19	2,659	22
15	Jakub Menšík	21	2,495	21

Top Indians ▶



Sumit Nagal
Rank 247 ▼ 11 spots



Dhakshinewar Suresh
Rank 367 ▲ 1 spot



Test Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Harry Brook	861	898
2	Steve Smith	840	947
3	Joe Root	816	932
4	Travis Head	811	884
5	Temba Bavuma	775	806
6	Rachin Ravindra	740	740
7	Rishabh Pant	713	801
8	Daryl Mitchell	710	804
9	Shubman Gill	709	807
10	Kamindu Mendis	706	784

ODI Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Shubman Gill	801	841
2	Daryl Mitchell	794	840
3	Virat Kohli	767	908
4	Rohit Sharma	758	879
5	Ibrahim Zadran	719	756
6	Babar Azam	689	894
7	Joe Root	674	810
8	Shai Hope	673	782
9	Charith Asalanka	659	705
10	Harry Tector	653	730

T20I Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Ishan Kishan	913	916
2	Abhishek Sharma	862	931
3	Sahibzada Farhan	848	848
4	Phil Salt	799	881
5	Dewald Brevis	789	806
6	Pathum Nissanka	751	796
7	Jos Buttler	748	794
8	Tilak Varma	740	845
9	Harry Brook	734	734
10	Mitchell Marsh	706	706

Test Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Mitchell Starc	872	872
2	Matt Henry	861	870
3	Ollie Robinson	856	856
4	Jasprit Bumrah	853	908
5	Pat Cummins	841	914
6	Marco Jansen	825	825
7	Kagiso Rabada	807	902
8	Scott Boland	804	820
9	Josh Hazlewood	783	864
10	Noman Ali	777	853

ODI Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Rashid Khan	714	775
2	Abrar Ahmed	675	675
3	Jofra Archer	649	682
4	Mitchell Santner	644	656
5	Maheesh Theekshana	641	680
6	Keshav Maharaj	626	737
7	Shaheen Afridi	604	691
8	Mehidy Hasan Miraz	602	722
9	Adil Rashid	599	671
10	Kuldeep Yadav	596	757

T20I Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Rashid Khan	744	828
2	Abrar Ahmed	736	757
3	Adil Rashid	710	747
4	Adam Zampa	700	746
5	Varun Chakaravarthy	678	818
6	Nathan Ellis	675	678
7	Wanindu Hasaranga	668	809
8	Mohammad Nawaz	658	672
9	Maheesh Theekshana	658	686
10	Jasprit Bumrah	650	783

FLICKR/STLCHESSCLUB

PROUD MOMENT

Manu, Tajinderpal named India's flag-bearers for opening ceremony



FILE PHOTOS

Double Olympic medal-winning shooter Manu Bhaker and two-time defending shot put champion Tajinderpal Singh Toor were named India's flag-bearers for the Asian Games opening ceremony. "Manu will be one of the flag-bearers," chef de mission Sahdev Yadav said. Later, the AFI confirmed Tajinderpal as the second flag-bearer.

SWANSONG

Shuttler Prannoy says Aichi-Nagoya will be his final Asian Games



GETTY IMAGES

Indian shuttler H.S. Prannoy has said that the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games will be his last appearance at the continental extravaganza. "Yes, this is my last Asian Games. I'm pretty much sure," he said. Prannoy, who won an individual bronze medal at the last edition in Hangzhou, will compete in the men's team event in Japan.

WORDS OF PRAISE

India is a good model: FIH chief's advice to other Asian countries



FILE PHOTO

International Hockey Federation (FIH) president Tayyab Ikram has lauded India's approach over the past few years and urged the other Asian nations to emulate the eight-time Olympic gold medallist to rise on the global stage. "India is a good model to see where it was and where it is today," he said ahead of the Asiad.

ALL IS WELL

Every athlete, coach, official has an accommodation: OCA official



FILE PHOTO

Every athlete, every coach, every official has an accommodation. No single accredited person is without one. Every National Olympic Committee sent a longlist for participation with a total of 26,000 athletes requested. We came to the final shortlist just seven to 10 days ago — Director-General of the OCA Husain Al Musallam.

Time for the Indian athletes to make it count

The preparations are done and the hard yards put in as the country aims to match or even better the record haul at the previous edition in Hangzhou; hockey teams eye Olympic berth

ASIAN GAMES

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

The number of athletes may have been reduced but India's ambitions of flexing its sporting muscle at the continental level will be tested when the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games officially kickstart at the Paloma Mizuho Stadium here on Saturday.

The quadrennial event, which began in India and which the country hopes to host again in near future for the third time, will have 501 Indian athletes in 259 medal events across 36 disciplines competing for a total of 356 medals. With 106 medals in the previous edition, any hopes of getting anywhere close to it would mean a fifth of Indian athletes finishing on the podium.

The record haul in Hangzhou has raised expectations but the country would do well to add a tinge of reality to temper them. With an ambitious



Proven performers: The likes of Tejaswin (athletics), Sindhu (badminton) and Mirabai (weightlifting) will be under the spotlight as they are expected to lead India's charge for medals. FILE PHOTOS

target of being in the top-10 in the medal tally by the 2036 Olympics, the performances at Aichi-Nagoya Games will provide both — a practical assessment of where Indian sports stands after the high of 2023 and a template for course correction to ensure the long-term targets remain feasible.

No one will be more in

the spotlight than the track and field athletes and the shooters, who contributed almost half of the total medals in Hangzhou.

Among the latter, Manu Bhaker — who along with shotputter Tajinderpal Singh Toor will be India's flag-bearers — on Saturday — will deservedly be the one to watch.

But there are others too,

some bringing youth (Tilottam Sen and Ashi Chouksey in rifle and Esha Singh and Suruchi Phogat in pistol) and others experience (Rahi Sarnobat).

And then there are those that have both, the likes of Aishwary Pratap Singh Tomar and Anish Bhanwal leading this group.

The situation is same in

athletics. With Neeraj Chopra out with injury, the mantle of doing the heavy lifting among the 74-member strong contingent will fall on the proven performers — Tejaswin Shankar, Murali Sreeshankar and Tajinderpal on the field. On the track, the return of Avinash Sable would be a welcome sight, the steeple-chaser along with Gulveer

Singh the biggest bet for a medal, even gold.

On the badminton court, P.V. Sindhu would be hoping for one last hurrah in her pursuit of a maiden Asian title while Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty will be looking for more consistency after a topsy-turvy year so far in terms of results and injury concerns in their tit-

le defence.

Women boxers and compound archers are also expected to add to the medal count while Mirabai Chanu will be up against it in search of her first medal in the event, 12 years after her debut in Incheon and three years after a shock exit.

Among the teams, hockey will expectedly be the

main attraction with tickets to LA28 at stake for both men and women.

The recent outings at the World Cup is unlikely to have much impact, specially the men, who will only have to guard against complacency. For the women, China would be the biggest challenge but recent form gives hope.

Cricket will get the eyeballs, as it is bound to, but in terms of competition, there will be little by way of excitement unless either of the genders have a terrible day in their title defences.

The men, in particular, would be hoping to earn legitimacy for their title, given the final against Afghanistan in 2023 was declared on the basis of ranking after being washed out.

The men's kabaddi team too will be itching to prove their win last time was not a fluke and put all the bad memories of a rancorous-filled final against Iran to rest.

The preparations are done, the hard yards put in. It's time to reap the results.

Indian contingent formally welcomed amidst confusion



Starting trouble: The disorganised planning meant India's flag-hoisting ceremony was delayed by around an hour. R.V. MOORTHY

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

The Asian Games chaos in Aichi-Nagoya continued ahead of the formal opening ceremony on Saturday, with the official welcome ceremony for several nations, including India, marred by disruptions, delays and confusion.

The Indian contingent, along with those from North Korea, Yemen, Palestine, Timor-Leste and Taiwan, was supposed to have its flag-hoisting ceremony at the Garden Pier — where the container accommodation is — at 1.30 p.m. local time in the second session of the day, but the disorganised planning meant it didn't happen before 2.30 p.m. and after a series of stops, starts and going backwards and forwards.

The delegations arrived on time and were assembled near the flag-hoisting area for at least half an hour. India's representatives — chef de mission Sah-

dev Yadav and deputy CDMs Anjali Bhagwat, Alakananda Ashok, Lijo David Thottan and A. Sharath Kamal — kept waiting and were about to walk on to the raising area before being asked to return to the waiting area for further communication.

There was no clarity, and no one had any information on the reasons behind the delay.

"There is some problem, but we don't know what it is. We are also trying to find out," the volunteers and officials at the venue said.

"The communication between the Olympic Council of Asia Executive Board and Organising Committee was not well... that's why this happened," a statement from the organisers later clarified.

Sahdev admitted he was also experiencing something like this for the first time. At Aichi-Nagoya, however, it was just another in the already long list of issues plaguing the edition.

It's a stroll in the park for India against Japan

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

Cricket barely scratches the sporting surface in Japan but there is no dearth of fans here for a sport that many would struggle to identify on screen. And no one has more, at least among the volunteers at the Korogi Sports Park, than Harmanpreet Kaur.

Even though the Indian captain did not come out to bat as India first decimated the Japanese batting, then strolled past the 58-run target in five overs for an eight-wicket win, the player with jersey No. 23 remains famous.

"I don't know the name but No. 23, I like her. My friend is an Indian and he also likes her game a lot. I really like watching the sport and her game," a volunteer gushed.

The venue is not for the easy-goers. Changing at least two train lines — three for some — and then walking for 15-20 minutes to reach the venue that at other times is a baseball field, a sport far more popular in the country, quite a few suffered heatstrokes and had to be administered fluids under the scorching sun.

With open temporary stands and barely any provision for shade, only the hardcore fans turned up. Among those were Virendra Maja and Aniket Yagnik, who took leave from work and came all the way from Osaka to watch the



Aggressive: Shafali finished the chase in a hurry. R.V. MOORTHY

Indian team play.

The two, originally from Madhya Pradesh, are big fans of Smriti Mandhana and Shreyanka Patil.

"It is a proud moment for us to watch the Indian women's team play in Japan.

"We applied for leave from work and drove here to cheer for them. It feels special," Maja said.

On the field, Shree Charani knifed through the Japan batting for a four wick-

et haul, then Shafali Verma's unbeaten 15-ball 40 meant the game was over in a blink.

The reward is a repeat of the Asia Cup semifinal against Bangladesh, a challenge that will be tougher than Friday's outing. Jersey No. 23 will, however, have the crowd behind her.

The scores: Japan 57 in 19.5 overs (Ayaka Kato-Stafford 25, Shree Charani 4/10, Shafali Verma 2/13) lost to India 59/2 in 5 overs (Shafali 40 n.o.).

Sindhu has a good chance, says Saina

Ashwin Achal

Saina Nehwal believes that P.V. Sindhu's big match temperament will hold her in good stead at the 2026 Asian Games.

After a dip in fortunes, Sindhu produced a vintage performance to clinch the Japan Open title a few months ago.

The 31-year-old became the first Indian shuttler to win the Japan Open, on the back of an impressive straight games win over local favourite Akane Yamaguchi in the final.

"Sometimes, at the highest level, you go up and down over one or two years. But having won the Japan Open, and coming close to defeating Wang Zhi in the World Championship round-of-16, I think Sindhu has a very good chance of winning at the Asian Games," Saina said in a virtual media interaction on Friday.

"And it's in Japan, where she has always performed well. She is experienced. She is a big tournament

player; I've never seen her getting tense.

"She is always very disciplined and she concentrates very well," Saina, the first Indian woman badminton player to reach the World No. 1 ranking, added.

Saina expects the Indian contingent to return home with at least three medals.

"We have winners in most events - Sindhu, Tanvi (Sharma) and Ashmita (Chaliha), Ayush (Shetty) in men's singles, and the men's doubles combination of Satwik and Chirag. Treasa (Jolly) and Gayatri (Gopichand) won the bronze medal in the World championships.

"Overall, the team looks very strong and confident. Of course, there are big expectations in these big tournaments, which adds a little bit more pressure. But I would say that we can definitely come back with three medals at least," Saina said.

(Watch Asian Games live and exclusive on Sony Sports Network and Sony LIV).



Gayatri and Treasa... big hopes. FILE PHOTO: SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR



Quimcy and Imran Beg... still in the fray. INSTAGRAM/QUIMCYY

Quimcy closes in on historic teqball medal

Press Trust of India
NAGOYA

Quimcy Joaquim Dsouza is just a win away from securing a historic medal for India in teqball, which is making its Asian Games debut.

She marched into the women's singles semifinals here on Friday.

Quimcy stunned top-seeded Yuina Sakamoto of Japan 10-12, 12-11, 13-11 in her opening Group A match before defeating Cambodia's Koemyean DY 12-9, 12-7 to top her pool and qualify for the last-four stage.

Quimcy, who had got a bye in the quarterfinals, will take on Indonesia's Sumaya on Saturday.

Quimcy and Mohammed Anas Imran Beg, however, lost 7-12, 10-12 to Vietnam's Hoang Minh Tan Nguyen and Gia Nghi Trinh in the quarterfinals of the mixed doubles event.

But the duo still has a chance to finish on the podium on Sunday as it won the repechage tie against the Filipino pair of Jhoana Abulencia and Prince Augustin 12-3, 12-6.

INBRIEF



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Sooryavanshi will have to wait for his opportunity: Gambhir

Asked about the decision to bring back Sanju Samson into the XI at the expense of 15-year-old Vaibhav Sooryavanshi in the T20I series win over Afghanistan, India coach Gautam Gambhir said: “I was very clear that we will go back to the combination we had during the World Cup. If a team has gone unbeaten in one World Cup and (then) defended the title, it’s a gun team. These guys do not become bad after two or three failures. Vaibhav will have to wait for his opportunity”.



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Nitish’s bowling returns a huge positive, says Gambhir

India head coach Gautam Gambhir termed Nitish Kumar’s bowling returns as a huge positive from the series win over Afghanistan. The all-rounder claimed six scalps. “It has been a huge plus for us. There are not many who can bowl and bat in the middle-order. The more he is going to bowl in international cricket, the better he is going to get,” Gambhir said after the third and final T20I on Thursday.



Buttler becomes first batter to reach 15,000 T20 runs

England’s Jos Buttler became the first batter to reach 15,000 T20 runs, achieving the feat in the six-wicket win over Sri Lanka in the second T20I in Cardiff on Thursday. The 36-year-old has done so in 528 matches (497 innings) at an average of 35.46 and a strike rate of 147.46. Buttler also surpassed West Indies’ Kieron Pollard as the highest run-scorer in T20 cricket.

The scores: Sri Lanka 145/9 in 20 overs (Nissanka 37, Asalanka 31, Archer 2/34, Dawson 3/32, Overton 2/23) lost to England 146/4 in 12.1 overs (Buttler 30, Banton 52 n.o.). **Toss:** England; **PoM:** Dawson.

Head the hero as Australia wins series against Zimbabwe

Opener Travis Head smashed a 75-ball hundred in Australia’s series-clinching 84-run victory over Zimbabwe in the second ODI in Harare on Friday. Head was well supported by captain Mitchell Marsh’s 53 and Cooper Connolly’s 78 in Australia’s total of 356 for six. Zimbabwe never looked like reaching the target, despite five of the top six batters scoring 30 or more.

The scores: Australia 356/6 in 50 overs (Marsh 53, Head 112, Connolly 78, Peake 41 n.o.) bt Zimbabwe 272 in 48.3 overs (Raza 45); **Toss:** Zimbabwe; **PoM:** Head.

Betis climbs to third in LaLiga with victory over Getafe

Ez Abde scored on Thursday as Betis won 1-0 at Getafe to continue its strong start to the Spanish season and climb to third.

The results: Real Betis 1 (Abde 45) bt Getafe 0; Malaga 1 (Dotor 12) lost to Villarreal 3 (Moleiro 40, Gueye 45+2, 86-pen).

LIVE TELECAST

Premier League: SS Select 1, 2 & JioHotstar, 5, 7.30 & 10 p.m.
LaLiga: FanCode, 5.30, 7.45, 10 p.m. & 12.30 a.m. (Sunday)
Serie A: Unite8 Sports 1, 2 & Z5 App, 6.30, 9.30 p.m. & 12.15 a.m. (Sunday)
Bundesliga: Unite8 Sports 1, 2 & Z5 App, 7 & 10 p.m.
England vs Sri Lanka: Third T20I, Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 7 p.m.
Asian Games: Day 2, Sony Sports Ten 5 & LIV, 5.30 a.m. (Sunday)
Cricknet: Asian Games (Women), Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 5.30 a.m. (Sunday)

Agarkar’s eventful stint as chief selector all but over

BCCI secretary Saikia plays his cards close to his chest and says that a decision will be taken in 15 days’ time; former wicketkeeper Parthiv emerges front-runner to replace the Mumbaiakar

CRICKET

Amol Karhadkar
MUMBAI

Ajit Agarkar’s three-year tenure as chairman of the senior men’s selection committee has effectively come to an end, with the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) now set to initiate the process of finding his replacement.

The BCCI’s 95th Annual General Meeting (AGM) here on Friday authorised the office-bearers to suitably fill vacancies, in line with the recent convention. Multiple member representatives who attended the AGM confirmed to *The Hindu* that, on the sidelines of the meeting, the office-bearers informed delegates that the board would initiate the process to find the Mumbaiakar’s successor.

A BCCI office-bearer, speaking on condition of anonymity, also confirmed that “Agarkar has formally



Enough is enough: According to a source, Agarkar has formally informed the BCCI that he doesn’t wish to continue. FILE PHOTO

informed the BCCI just before the AGM that he doesn’t wish to continue as a selector” after his term ends on October 4.

BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia, however, remained non-committal about Agarkar’s future. “Today, there was no discussion on any individual,” he said after the AGM. “We still have 15 days to go. Fifteen days is a long time in the world of cricket. We have 15 days’ time, we will take a decision at an appropriate time. We will let you know about it.”

Agarkar remained unavailable for a comment.

The former India speedster took charge of the selection committee in July 2023 and was at the centre of several significant decisions during his stint. These included elevating Suryakumar Yadav as T20I captain in place of then vice-captain Hardik Pandya in 2024, overseeing a period of high-profile Test retirements, replacing Rohit Sharma as the ODI captain with Shubman Gill after India’s Champions Trophy triumph last year

Nitish and Hardik can be part of the same XI, feels Gambhir

Vivek Krishnan
NEW DELHI

In a series win as emphatic as India’s 3-0 sweep over Afghanistan, there will be many bright spots to revel in. But if there was a fresh takeaway from the T20I series, it was Nitish Kumar’s enhanced contribution with the ball. Back from a quadriceps injury, the 23-year-old seam-bowling all-rounder started shakily with figures of 2-0-30-0 in his first outing, but bounced back with three scalps each in the next two games.

More than the wickets, which can come arbitrarily in a format where batters are obliged to attack, the fact that Nitish bowled at brisk pace in different phases was heartening. Particularly in light of the prolonged absence of Hardik Pandya, who has been sidelined with injury since the conclusion of the Indian Premier League.

The 32-year-old is expected to return to action when India-A plays three one-dayers against Australia-A in Puducherry from



Valuable assets: All-rounders Nitish and Hardik could have a big role to play in next year’s ODI World Cup. FILE PHOTO

October 6 to 11.

With India’s next big priority being the 2027 ODI World Cup, coach Gautam Gambhir understandably wants both all-rounders to be fit and firing.

“We know how important seam bowling all-rounders will be in a year’s time when we go to South Africa. The more the merrier. Sometimes we could even go on to play both of them in the XI,” Gambhir said on Thursday. “At the moment, Hardik cannot bowl 10 overs. He hasn’t played cricket since the IPL. So, we don’t want to push him into international cricket be-

cause it can be extremely tough on your body.”

Gambhir conceded that the Indian players’ recent injury breakdowns weren’t ideal. He was echoing the views of Test and ODI skipper Shubman Gill, who highlighted the issue after the tour of England in July.

“Yes (it is a problem), especially in Tests and ODIs. You want your best players to play as many Tests and ODIs. It’s not fair on a young captain as well if he doesn’t get the best team playing regularly. It is important for Shubman to get the best playing XI as many times as he can,” Gambhir stated.

Yashbardhan’s all-round show takes India past Australia

YOUTH ODI SERIES

Shayan Acharya
RAJKOT

India u-19 edged Australia u-19 by seven runs in a rain-shortened youth ODI at the Niranjan Shah Stadium on Friday, with Yashbardhan Singh Chauhan starring with both bat and ball. He top-scored with 54 off 34 balls (5x4, 2x6) before returning to claim two wickets.

After heavy rain reduced the contest to 20 overs a side, India posted 182 for six. Inserted to bat, India was 88 for four before Yashbardhan and Anvay Dravid steadied the innings with a 69-run stand.

Anvay, the younger son of Rahul Dravid, smashed 38 off 18 balls (2x4, 3x6) before being bowled by Eli Brain.



Yashbardhan. SAURASHTRA CA

Years after Virender Sehwag and Dravid shared the India dressing room, their sons were together in National colours at the u-19 level. On his debut, Aaryavir Sehwag (28) showed flashes of his father’s attacking strokeplay, but fell to Spencer Green. As Aaryavir tried to take on the Australian attack, Sehwag watched on from the stands, following every shot.

Australia’s Neel Patel and Hayden Barbulovic added 58 for the opening wicket. But Yashbardhan



Sehwag. SHAYAN ACHARYA

broke the stand, having Barbulovic (40) stumped by Anvay, and also removed Neel for 45.

Jack Czosnek’s 55 off 27 balls (6x4, 3x6) kept Australia in the hunt while Arjun Rajput dismissed Zed Hollick before C. Venkata removed Czosnek. Australia needed 11 off the final over, but Mohit Ulva kept his cool to guide India home.

The scores: India u-19 182/6 in 20 overs (Yashbardhan 54, Anvay 38) bt Australia u-19 175/7 in 20 overs (Neel 45, Barbulovic 40, Czosnek 55). **Toss:** Australia; **PoM:** Yashbardhan.



Going the distance: Chung brought all his experience into play to emerge victorious after more than three hours. AP

Korea races away to a 2-0 lead against India

DAVIS CUP

Press Trust of India
SEOUL

India’s hopes of making the Davis Cup Final 8 were pushed to the brink after Dhakshineswar Suresh and Sumit Nagal squandered promising starts to lose their respective singles, leaving the visitors trailing 0-2 against Korea at the end of the opening day of their Qualifier tie here on Friday.

Dhakshineswar lost the first match of his fledgling Davis Cup career when Korea’s No.1 player Soonwoo Kwon beat him 3-6, 6-3, 6-4. The onus to bring India back was on India No.1 Nagal but he also frittered

away a solid start to lose 6-2, 4-6, 5-7 to the experienced Hyon Chung after battling for more than three hours.

Chung showed the temperament of a big player as he earned points when it mattered the most.

Kwon has not lost a Davis Cup match at home and that trend continued.

Now India needs to win all three matches on the final day to advance to the knockout stage which has happened only twice in India’s history: in 2010 against Brazil at home and in 2018 against China in an away tie.

The results: Korea 2 leads India 0 (Soonwoo Kwon bt Dhakshineswar Suresh 3-6, 6-3, 6-4; Hyon Chung bt Sumit Nagal 2-6, 6-4, 7-5).



Top show: Humpy got the better of Tsolakidou as India eased past Greece. FIDE

Nihal, Gukesh help India beat Italy; women keep winning

CHESS OLYMPIAD

Sports Bureau

Nihal Sarin posted his third straight win, but Arjun Erigaisi had to survive a scare, as India beat Italy 3-1 in the third round of the Chess Olympiad at Samarkand. World champion D. Gukesh scored a win on the fourth board on Friday.

Arjun’s was one of the day’s last games to finish, as he drew with Luca Moroni in 64 moves.

Before that, Gukesh had beaten Sabino Brunello and Nihal defeated Francesco Sonis. On the top board, R. Praggnanandhaa split the point with Lorenzo Lodici.

The defending champion thus has won all its

three matches.

The Indian women, who also were crowned champions at the Budapest Olympiad two years ago, once again played more impressively than their male counterparts. They made short work of Greece 3.5-0.5.

Koneru Humpy beat Stavroula Tsolakidou on the top board and avenged her defeat at the Global Chess League final in Bengaluru on Sunday. Vantika Agrawal and B. Savitha Shri also won, while Divya Deshmukh drew.

Important results:

Open: India bt Italy 3-1 (R. Praggnanandhaa drew with Lorenzo Lodici; Arjun Erigaisi drew with Luca Moroni; Nihal Sarin bt Francesco Sonis; D. Gukesh bt Sabino Brunello). Uzbekistan bt Austria 3-1; USA bt

Denmark 2.5-1.5; China bt Bulgaria 3.5-0.5. Germany bt Uzbekistan (2) 2.5-1.5; Azerbaijan bt Switzerland 3-1; France bt Kazakhstan 3.5-0.5. Hungary bt Slovenia 2.5-1.5; Armenia bt Sweden 2.5-1.5; Ukraine bt Slovakia 3-1. Armenia bt Sweden 2.5-1.5; Lithuania drew with England 2-2; Ukraine bt Slovakia 3-1; Spain bt Belarus 3-1.

Women: India bt Greece 3.5-0.5 (Koneru Humpy bt Stavroula Tsolakidou; Divya Deshmukh drew with Anastasia Avramidou; Vantika Agrawal bt Ekaterini Pavlidou; B. Savitha Shri bt Antonia Christodoulaki). Uzbekistan bt Indonesia 3-1; USA bt Cuba 3.5-0.5; Azerbaijan bt Sweden 2.5-1.5; Poland bt Latvia 4-0; Germany bt Belarus 2.5-1.5; China bt Turkiye 3-1. Mongolia bt Peru 2.5-1.5; Kazakhstan bt Slovenia 3.5-0.5. Armenia bt Croatia 4-0; Iran bt France 3-1; Poland bt Latvia 4-0; Serbia bt Canada 2.5-1.5.

Zuccaro for President Of India Gold Cup

51. **1. COSMIC GIFT, 2. MATERIALITY, 3. MY WAY MY RULES**

3. FALAKNUMA TROPHY (DIV. I) (1,100m), 3-y-o and upward, rated 20 to 45, Cat. III, 3.05: 1. Coming Home (3) B. Nikhil 60.5, 2. She’s A Bomb (2) Surendra 60, 3. American Affair (1) Ashad Asbar 57.5, 4. La Quinta (4) Akshay K 57.5, 5. Flare (8) V.S. Shekawat 55, 6. Leggo (10) Kuldeep Sr. 54.5, 7. Commanding Warrior (7) Surya Prakash 53, 8. Golden Aura (9) G. Naresh 52, 9. Santorini Sky (5) D.S. Deora 51.5 and 10. Rate Of Interest (6) Arjun 50.

1. SHE’S A BOMB, 2. LA QUINTA, 3. AMERICAN AFFAIR

4. TOTARAM’S CUP (1,200m) (Terms), 3-y-o upward, Cat. I, 3.40: 1. Celestial (7) Gaurav 58, 2. One N Only (9) Akshay K 54.5, 3. Shadow Of The Moon (6) Saqlain 53.5, 4. Uchchaishravas (8) Neeraj 53.5, 5. Black Onyx (2) D.S. Deora 52, 6. Detective (1) Vikram 52, 7. Calista Girl (3) Bhawani 50.5, 8. Emerald Touch (4) M.S. Deora 50.5 and 9. Reigning Beauty (5) Santosh Raj 50.5.

1. ONE N ONLY, 2. UCHCHAIHSHRAVAS, 3. CELESTIAL

5. PRESIDENT OF INDIA GOLD CUP (Gr. II) (2,400m), (Terms), 4-y-o and upward, 4.15: 1. Duke Of Tuscany (7) R. Ajinkya 60, 2. Ramiel (1) Antony Raj 58, 3. DYF (5) Yash Narredu 57, 4. Zuccaro (6) Vivek G 56.5, 5. Miracle Star (3) Trevor 55.5, 6. High Command (4) P. Ajeeth K 53 and 7. Vyasa (2) Ashad Asbar 52.

1. ZUCCARO, 2. DUKE OF TUSCANY, 3. RAMIEL

6. NELSTON PLATE (1,600m), 4-y-o and upward, rated 20 to 45, Cat. III, 4.50: 1. Onslaught (2) Imran Chisty 61, 2. Hoping High (8) Mohit 58.5, 3. Silver Arrow (9) A.A. Vikram 58.5, 4. Quintessential (1) P. Ajeeth K 57, 5. Photograph (10) G. Naresh 55, 6. Valledonna (6) Antony Raj 55, 7. Shubhraj (3) Rafique Sk. 52.5, 8. American Gangster (5) D.S. Deora 52, 9. December Rain (7) Arjun 52 and 10. See My Attitude (4) Surya Prakash 50.

1. QUINTESSENTIAL, 2. HOPING HIGH, 3. ONSLAUGHT
Day’s Best: **ONE N ONLY**
Jackpot: 2, 3, 4, 5 & 6.
Mini Jackpot: 3, 4, 5 & 6.
Trebble: (1) 1, 2 & 3, (1) 4, 5 & 6.
Tanala: All races.